

Voyages of the Suther

By Christopher Vardeman

Chapter 1: Mining matters

Captain Hadler took one deep breath, then another, and another—because apparently, that's what you do when your submarine's finances look like they were scribbled by a toddler. Not only did he run the sub and manage a crew who probably deserved better, but hey, he was also a "free captain" in what was left of Europa's submarine travel ecosystem. Lucky him, right? Ever since Earth ghosted them a few years back, the radiation from Jupiter decided to up the ante. Civilization? Oh yeah, that started unraveling like a cheap sweater the moment Earth stopped sending care packages. Parts, supplies—you name it. Those handy shipments that used to magically arrive? Poof, gone.

Not that Captain Hadler knew anyone who actually came on the last shuttles—nope, just some vague bad vibes from the few folks who did. The word on the street (or rather, the frozen surface of Europa) was that Earth's superpowers probably had one final tantrum and pressed the big red buttons. What else could have knocked out communications so thoroughly? Nothing else would make every last shipment and message vanish like that.

Now, everyone on Europa was left nervously twiddling their thumbs, wondering if they were the last ones standing. The cobbled-together economies of science, production, and trade that had sprouted up around the science depots and minor colonies? Yeah, that's all they had now—congratulations, it's their problem forever.

If Captain Hadler was lucky—and that was a big "if"—he had maybe a few dozen weeks of finances left. Enough to pay the crew, cover docking fees, scrounge up supplies, and grease the right palms to keep the work trickling in. All of this was swirling around in his mind when his chief engineer walked through the door, sporting that signature furrowed brow that practically screamed, "Bad news incoming." Oh great, Captain Hadler thought, here comes a conversation that's definitely going to make my day.

Captain Hadler looked up at his chief engineer, immediately clocking the mess of oil and wax smeared across the man's uniform. Yep, he'd definitely been elbows-deep in some engine problem. Mentally bracing for impact, Captain Hadler watched as the engineer hesitantly approached. The bad news was practically written all over his face, so rather than drag out the suspense, the captain barked, "Well, what is it?"

The chief engineer flinched slightly at the sharp tone in the captain's voice. "Well, Captain," he started, a bit defensively, "the Suther-class really wasn't built for what we've been putting that engine through. Hot-swapping between the electromagnetic drive and the diesel... yeah, it hasn't exactly been kind to the transmission..."

The captain stared at his chief engineer, and for a moment, his mind drifted back to when they first met all those years ago. He shuddered at the thought of how much time had passed since then. Back when they were both scraping by on that rickety little shuttlecraft, the two of them barely keeping it afloat under Provost Harbormaster Gretton's watchful eye at Anne-Arbor Station. Those were simpler, albeit scrappier days—when they fought just to keep that shuttle from falling apart. And now, here they were, dealing with problems on a much grander scale but somehow still the same old struggle.

With a knowing look, Captain Hadler glanced back at his long-time friend and asked, "How much is it gonna cost?"

Indignant, the chief engineer shot back, "What, Captain? You don't even want to know what broke?"

The captain just sighed and replied, "I trust you, Eddie. Just tell me how much it's gonna cost first."

Eddie let out a deep breath, rubbing the back of his neck as he mentally tallied the damage. "Well, Captain, if we're lucky—really lucky—we can get by with about two months' worth of pay. But that's assuming we can scrounge the parts locally. If we have to order anything special from one of the other colonies..." He trailed off, letting the silence fill in the grim details.

Captain Hadler closed his eyes for a moment, letting the number sink in. Two months of pay. That was cutting it too close for comfort. "And if we don't get it fixed?" he asked, already dreading the answer.

Eddie shrugged, but it wasn't the carefree kind of shrug. "Then we limp along on diesel alone, but that's not a long-term solution. Eventually, something else is going to give, and when it does..." He didn't have to finish the sentence. They both knew what would happen if the engine gave out completely, and it wasn't pretty.

Captain Hadler let out a long sigh, feeling the weight of the situation pressing down on him. "Alright, Eddie, do what you can. Patch it up for now, and we'll figure out the rest later. Just... keep us running."

Eddie nodded, the same determined look he always had when things got rough. "You got it, Captain. I'll do my best. But just know, we're on borrowed time." With that, he turned and headed back to the engine room, leaving the captain to stare at the balance sheets and wonder just how much longer they could keep this ship—and themselves—afloat.

Considering their submarine was on borrowed time with damaged parts, any voyage from here on out was a gamble. And a dangerous one at that, given that transporting goods was their primary job. Eddie had left behind a wreath of paperwork as he went—parts lists as long as the captain's arm. Captain Hadler sighed as he skimmed the documents. Most of it was standard wear and tear, the usual suspects when it came to electromagnetic drive components. The parts

themselves were common enough, found on just about any submarine, but the devil was in the details. The size and class of the components they needed were more specialized—denser, heavier, and harder to come by. Drive collars, impeller rings, plastic and rubberized bearings, bushings of all shapes and sizes—the list went on.

The only silver lining in this sea of bad news was that the Suther-class was a fairly popular light cargo hauler. Plenty of them had been built, and they were still plying the routes between outposts on Europa's seas. Plus, the Suther had a useful edge in this economy—it was moon pool compatible. This meant Captain Hadler could pull up to a colony's moon pool-equipped cargo dock, pop the hatches, and have the cargo unloaded quickly, making it perfect for bulk transfers in the tight, chaotic trade networks that now defined life on Europa.

But that also meant that every trip they took, every time they pushed the engine just a little harder, they were rolling the dice. And with each roll, the stakes got higher.

As captain, he knew every inch of his vessel. Looking over the parts list, he could almost visualize where each component would go, what it would replace, and how it would impact the ship's performance. The electromagnetic drive was ubiquitous for submarines on Europa—it was practically their lifeblood. While most subs on the moon ran on either diesel or nuclear power, a rare few boasted the capability to switch to manual diesel impeller drives.

The design and functionality of submarines had been well understood by humanity long before they came to Europa. The experience and technology transfer had been relatively smooth—until they had to adapt to the unique demands of the icy moon. The prevalence of electromagnetic drives and the intricate aquatic construction techniques that had developed here were a testament to how quickly things had evolved.

As he considered the intricacies of their current predicament, Captain Hadler couldn't help but marvel at how the technology had adapted and changed to meet the challenges of Europa. But now, with the pressure mounting and supplies running low, he had to keep his ship and crew running on the fragile balance of borrowed time.

Captain Hadler couldn't help but chuckle at the almost absurd ubiquity of nuclear technology on Europa. The density of nuclear engineers here was so high it could make even the most seasoned national security experts break into a sweat. It seemed like every other person on the moon had either worked with a reactor or had a vague but steady understanding of its complex machinery. After all, Europa's survival practically hinged on nuclear tech—from powering tiny seasteads to keeping bustling high-density colonies up and running.

Knowing how these reactors and their fuel systems functioned wasn't just a nice-to-have; it was as essential as knowing how your oxygen filtration system worked. It was the kind of knowledge you picked up just by being around, like how you learn to dodge puddles on a rainy day. If you

didn't understand the reactors, you might as well be asking how to pilot a submarine without any training. On Europa, nuclear know-how was practically a prerequisite for daily life, right up there with understanding why your coffee machine doesn't work if the power's out.

Captain Hadler couldn't help but be amused by the sheer absurdity of how ubiquitous nuclear technology was on Europa. It was as if the moon had its own covert league of nuclear engineers, so numerous they could make Earth's security experts look like novices. The depth and reach of nuclear tech here meant that anyone who had even the vaguest connection to reactors had to master their intricacies.

On Europa, handling nuclear reactors wasn't just a specialty—it was practically a survival skill. The moon's very existence hinged on nuclear power, making knowledge of these reactors as essential as knowing how to breathe. Whether you were running a small seastead or overseeing a dense colony, being clued in on nuclear tech was a must if you wanted to make it through the day. It's the kind of expertise that comes with the territory, much like knowing how to make a decent cup of coffee on a groggy Monday morning.

The motley crew of various national colonies fancied themselves as the grandly named "Coalition." By the time Captain Hadler had arrived on Europa years ago, as a starry-eyed newcomer eager to make his mark, the major Earth nations had each planted their flag somewhere on the moon. This meant that all the old-world grudges, vendettas, and petty squabbles had been neatly packed up and shipped along with them, ready to be unpacked and played out in the chilly expanses of their new home.

Naturally, as soon as times got tough, these old feuds flared up with all the subtlety of a bonfire at a gas station. The promise of Earth's support—whatever that was supposed to mean—had turned into a cruel joke. Initially, they'd receive a trickle of supplies, maybe some food, and occasionally a bulk shipment of highly specialized tech goods that couldn't be cobbled together locally. Back in the golden days, they might have seen a regular stream of bulk shipments and the like. But those were the days of yore—when "bulk" meant something more substantial than a few boxes of outdated parts and a vague promise of "someday."

Now, with the Coalition fraying at the edges and everyone scrambling just to keep the lights on, the old promises of Earth were as reliable as a broken compass. The vast support systems that once seemed like a given were now nothing more than distant memories, leaving the colonies to fend for themselves in the cold, harsh reality of Europa.

Captain Hadler pored over a mountain of data: expenditure charts, projected fuel usage plans, air scrubber filtration clogging rates, and particulate counts in various corners of the submarine. Each report was a glaring reminder of the ship's fragility and the tightrope they were walking to keep it operational.

Then came the health advisory report from the station's health inspector. Ah, the delightful specter of having a Coalition dockmaster deem your submarine unfit for duty. There was nothing quite like the terror of facing the bureaucratic hammer that could keep you tethered to the dock

while they confiscated your vessel—naturally, all in the name of the "greater good." After all, they couldn't have unsafe submarines endangering lives and losing cargo, not that it stopped cargo from mysteriously disappearing anyway.

In this cutthroat environment, the notion of "safety first" often translated to "bureaucratic red tape first." The irony was rich: while the Coalition's dockmasters were busy ensuring no unfit submarines were allowed to venture out, they were conveniently overlooking the fact that cargo still vanished with alarming regularity, often under the very noses of those enforcing the so-called safety protocols. It was as if the Coalition had perfected the art of making sure everyone looked good on paper while the real issues—like, you know, actually keeping submarines operational and cargo intact—took a backseat to their own labyrinthine procedures.

Captain Hadler decided he'd lingered long enough in the land of spreadsheets and dire forecasts. He grabbed a nearby hard-shell phone and dialed the bridge, the phone ringing with that infuriatingly patient tone that seemed to echo through the submarine's ventilation system. He could practically hear the ringtone bouncing through the ducts as he waited.

Finally, after what felt like an eternity, Sydney picked up. It only took a couple of rings—clearly, the young comms officer must have been finishing up a bathroom break. "Yes, Captain?" Sydney's voice came through, with just a hint of exasperation.

Sydney was relatively new and, as Captain Hadler saw it, needed to be kept out of the rough-and-tumble of the engineering crew who could be a bit "hard" with their humor. The captain kept him on comms to shield him from the more abrasive personalities onboard. It was part of the job, recognizing where each person fit best. Sometimes you needed to push people out of their comfort zones; other times, you kept them safely ensconced in roles where they could thrive.

"Put me through to the dockmaster, will you?" Hadler requested. "It's high time we talked about the price for filing a passage transit plan."

He glanced at the map and the stack of contracts in front of him, weighing which ones were feasible and which were pipe dreams. After a moment's thought, his mind settled on a supply run to a mining colony. It would be credits on the ton, but it was a safe bet and a reliable option.

"Cassar Leinna, mining station?" Hadler continued, jotting down the details. "Let's see if we can make that work."

Sydney patched him through to the obnoxiously dull holding signal, which seemed to be a test of patience in itself. After a few minutes of listening to the monotonous beep and buzz, Captain Hadler was finally greeted by the gruff, no-nonsense voice of the dockmaster. Of course, it was the same kind of gruff, salty demeanor that seemed to be a prerequisite for anyone running a dock or extorting prices from passing submarine commanders.

Hadler could almost hear the weariness in the dockmaster's voice—clearly, the man was long past his prime for the duties of actual submarine work, but still had enough spark left to make the life of any passing captain a little more difficult.

"Captain Hadler, what can I do for you?" the dockmaster growled, his tone suggesting that the last thing he wanted was to deal with another demanding client.

"Hello, dockmaster," Hadler began, his voice as smooth and polite as he could muster. "I'm looking to file a passage transit plan and get some quotes on fees. Thought it was about time we discussed the specifics."

There was a moment's pause, filled with the kind of heavy silence that only added to the feeling of inevitable exasperation. The dockmaster's response came with a layer of sarcasm wrapped in politeness, as if it were an art form perfected over years of grumpy exchanges.

"Well, Captain," he replied, "I'm sure you're aware that our rates aren't exactly what you'd call 'friendly.' But I'll be happy to give you the rundown if you're prepared for the usual spiel."

Hadler sighed inwardly. This was going to be one of those conversations—long-winded and laced with just enough sarcasm to make him question his life choices. He braced himself for the grueling details of time schedules and prices, knowing full well it would be anything but straightforward.

The dockmaster launched into his spiel, as if he were presenting the options for a high-stakes poker game rather than just transit services.

"Alright, Captain," he began, "you've got our most basic and popular option: the unassisted exit. We give you an air-powered pneumatic shunt off the dock edge, and you pilot your own way out. Simple, straightforward, and practically free."

He continued, clearly enjoying the moment. "Option two: for a mere 100 credits, we'll provide you with a 'Cassidor pilot shuttle.' They'll take you partway through the—let's see—Rasa delCasa drift. You'll be on your own with your charts after that, but hey, at least you'll get a bit of a push in the right direction."

Then, with a dramatic flourish, he introduced the pièce de résistance. "Or, if you're feeling fancy and want the full royal treatment, we can arrange for a patrol boat to escort you. That'll be a cool 1000 credits. Oh, and Alex—" he called out, presumably to an assistant, "what's the name of the boat again?"

A distant voice chimed in, "The Elburin, sir."

"Right, the Elburin. A full thousand credits for that option. Though, considering what I've heard about your contract, that might be a bit steep for what you're planning to get paid, Captain Hadler."

Hadler raised an eyebrow, imagining the smirk on the dockmaster's face. It was all part of the routine—a balance of sarcasm and salesmanship. He weighed his choices, knowing that while the 'unassisted exit' was the cheapest, it also came with its own set of challenges. The 'Cassidor pilot shuttle' was tempting, but he'd have to manage the tricky part of the journey on his own. And the full escort, while luxurious, was indeed a financial stretch.

"Well, dockmaster," Hadler said with a hint of wry humor, "it seems like my options are either to stretch my budget or to test my piloting skills in the drift. What a delightful predicament."

The dockmaster, as if channeling a telepathic shrug, waited patiently for Captain Hadler's decision, blissfully unaware that there was no visual connection on this particular comm line.

Captain Hadler, leaning over his comm station with the balance sheets spread out before him, mulled over his options. After a brief contemplation, he made his choice. "We'll go with the unassisted push. That's 20 credits, right? At least, that's what I overheard on the dock yesterday."

The dockmaster's response was as dry as the desert, but with an added layer of amusement. "Oh, no, no, no, Captain. That's the price for the locals. You must have heard the Dario over there on the berth next to you. He's always bragging about how he gets cheap rates from me, just because he's married to my sister. And just because you've managed to snag a cargo run at a decent rate from Kasaran Yards doesn't mean you're getting any tax breaks or sweet deals from us. They might have chipped in for half the docking ring, but they haven't paid my paycheck in over a month."

The dockmaster's voice carried a hint of bitterness, as if the unpaid wages were a personal affront. "So, you're looking at 50 credits for the unassisted exit. That's the rate for non-locals, like yourself. It's a bit more straightforward, but I promise it won't come with any unexpected family discounts or favoritism."

Captain Hadler raised an eyebrow. It seemed the dockmaster had a flair for making things complicated, but the new price was still reasonable compared to the alternatives.

"Understood," Hadler replied, keeping his tone measured. "Let's go with the 50-credit unassisted push. I'll take my chances with the drift."

"Good choice, Captain," the dockmaster said, his voice tinged with reluctant approval. "I'll get the arrangements started. Safe travels, and try not to get too cozy with the drift out there."

With a clearer picture of what it would take to get out of the dock, Captain Hadler turned his attention to what he needed from the Kasaran cargo rep. He now had to ensure that the cargo run would cover his expenses and ideally leave a margin for profit.

He reviewed the details of his contract and the anticipated costs. The balance sheets had shown a tight squeeze, and he needed to make sure that every credit was accounted for. His next move would be to renegotiate any terms if possible or at least confirm that the current arrangements would meet his needs. The key was to ensure that the revenue from the Kasaran cargo run would not only cover the docking and operational costs but also provide some buffer against any unforeseen expenses.

Hadler made a note to discuss the following points with the Kasaran cargo rep:

1. **Cargo Delivery Timelines:** Ensure the cargo delivery schedules align with his planned departure and arrival times.
2. **Payment Terms:** Clarify payment schedules and any advance payments needed to avoid cash flow issues.
3. **Contract Flexibility:** Negotiate any clauses related to delays or changes in cargo requirements, which could impact the run.
4. **Additional Costs:** Identify and agree on any potential additional costs that might arise during the cargo run or due to unforeseen delays.

With these points in mind, he prepared to make contact with the Kasaran rep, ready to finalize the details and ensure that the cargo run would be both viable and profitable.

Sydney rang up the Kasaran master contracts office, and after a few minutes of navigating the lively banter of a sprightly young secretary, Captain Hadler was finally put through to the contract manager. The kid on the other end was surprisingly young for the role, a fact that Hadler noted with a wry smile. The new generation on Europa seemed to either be seasoned old-timers or fresh-faced youngsters, with very little in between.

The conversation began with the usual pleasantries before diving into the nitty-gritty details of the contract.

Kasaran Contract Manager: "Hello, Captain Hadler. This is Mark from the Kasaran Master Contracts Office. I hear you're looking to finalize the details for your cargo run. What can I do for you today?"

Captain Hadler: "Hi, Mark. Yes, I'd like to go over the specifics of the delivery to Cassar Leinna mining station. I need to ensure everything is in order, especially with the current situation at the dock. I want to make sure we're clear on terms and any potential considerations."

Mark: "Absolutely. Let's get into it. We've got you scheduled for a standard cargo run, but I understand there might be some spare capacity. Is that correct?"

Hadler: "That's right. We have about 15 tons of additional space available. I'm hoping to make the most of that without compromising the primary contract."

Mark: "Got it. For the primary cargo, we're looking at a shipment of essential supplies and equipment for the mining operations. The delivery needs to be completed within the next two weeks to meet their operational needs. We've already accounted for the primary load, so let's focus on the spare capacity."

Hadler: "Great. What are my options for filling that extra space? I'd like to maximize our earnings without taking on anything too risky or outside our typical range."

Mark: "Well, we've got a few options. We could add some additional mining tools and spare parts that are in high demand. There's also a smaller contract for transporting some scientific equipment for a research outpost nearby. If you're interested, I can provide more details on these."

Hadler: "That sounds promising. Could you break down the additional costs and potential revenue for each option?"

Mark: "Sure thing. For the mining tools and spare parts, we're looking at about 200 credits per ton. It's a straightforward addition and aligns well with your current cargo. For the scientific equipment, it's a bit more niche. The payment is higher, around 350 credits per ton, but the handling might be more delicate, and there's a slight risk of delays due to the specialized nature of the cargo."

Hadler: "Understood. I'll need to weigh the risks and rewards. Can you also provide details on any potential issues or considerations we should be aware of, especially with the scientific equipment?"

Mark: "Of course. The scientific equipment requires careful handling due to its delicate nature. There's also a slight risk of customs inspections at the mining station due to its high-tech components. You might experience delays if there are any issues with the paperwork or inspections."

Hadler: "Noted. What's the deadline for making a decision on the additional cargo?"

Mark: "I'd say you have about 24 hours to finalize your decision. We need to ensure everything is booked and secured in time for the next shipment cycle. Let me know as soon as you can, and we'll get everything sorted out."

Hadler: "Alright, I'll review the options and get back to you shortly. Thanks for the information, Mark."

Mark: "You're welcome, Captain. Looking forward to your decision. Safe travels, and let me know if you need anything else."

Hadler ended the call, reflecting on the details. With the options laid out, he had to decide whether to take on the additional mining tools and spare parts or the more lucrative but riskier scientific equipment. The next step was to crunch the numbers and evaluate how each choice would impact their overall mission.

Captain Hadler knew what was coming next and braced himself. He reached for the small, unremarkable bottle of Europa grain alcohol—an acquired taste produced somewhere on the fringes of the moon, its exact origin a mystery even to him. He tossed back a quick shot, the harsh liquid burning a fiery trail down his throat. It was a ritual of sorts, a quick reminder that the decisions he made would ripple through every corner of his crew's lives. One shot was enough; he didn't want to overdo it and face the unpleasant aftereffects, particularly since he'd need his wits about him for the meeting to come.

With a resigned sigh, Hadler turned to the comms console and pressed the big red-orange button. The button, usually reserved for emergencies, was now broadcasting an all-hands notice throughout the submarine.

The ship's intercom crackled to life, and his voice came over the system, steady and authoritative.

"Attention all crew members," he announced. "This is Captain Hadler. I need all department heads to report to my office immediately. We've got a situation to discuss regarding our upcoming mission, including some new details that will affect all departments. Please make your way here promptly."

He set down the receiver, already mentally preparing for the myriad reactions from his department heads. This meeting would cover the new cargo arrangements, the changes in the route, and the potential impacts on their schedules and workloads. It was always a challenge to gather everyone and ensure smooth coordination, but it was a necessary step to keep operations running efficiently.

Hadler took a moment to look around his office, mentally rehearsing the key points he needed to address. He knew the briefing would be intense, with plenty of questions and concerns from his team. But he was ready to face it head-on, knowing that clear communication and decisive planning were crucial to navigating the complexities of their mission.

As Captain Hadler reviewed the ship's foodstuffs and rations projections, he prepared himself mentally for the upcoming meeting. He knew the intricacies of each department head's role and personal quirks well enough to anticipate their reactions, even those that would be less than ideal. For instance, he wasn't looking forward to explaining to his security chief why a portion of the ammo storage had been allocated as part of their cargo loadout. The security chief was meticulous about ammunition, and this would likely not sit well.

One by one, the department heads filtered into his office. Each arrival brought a mix of small talk and the occasional grumbled complaint about the short notice. The cramped quarters of the captain's office, with its minimal seating, meant that a formal seating arrangement wasn't possible. Instead, the department heads stood or leaned against the walls, making the atmosphere one of casual anticipation.

Captain Hadler observed them with a practiced eye. There was Chief Engineer Eddie, with his usual grease-streaked uniform and a look of cautious optimism. The comms officer, Sydney, was already nervously fiddling with his console, his youth showing through in his anxious demeanor. The security chief, who Hadler knew was not going to be thrilled about the ammo situation, had a stern expression that was unlikely to soften anytime soon. And of course, the rest of the heads of departments shuffled in, exchanging nods and murmured comments as they settled into the tight space.

The informal chat that ensued was a mix of good-natured banter and subdued grumbling about the disruption to their routines. Most of the mechanics, still in the middle of their second shift, would be clustered in the galley, trying to unwind over their meals. Hadler knew that shifting the meeting location to the galley would upset them further, adding unnecessary friction to an already delicate situation.

When everyone was finally present, Hadler took a deep breath, mentally bracing for the task ahead. He cleared his throat and addressed the gathered department heads.

"Alright, everyone," he began, his tone firm yet reassuring. "Thank you for coming on such short notice. I know it's not ideal, but we need to go over some critical details regarding our upcoming mission and the new cargo arrangements. I'll keep this as brief as possible, but we need to make sure we're all on the same page."

He gestured to a makeshift display on the wall, which flickered to life with the latest cargo and route details. "Let's get started with the key points, and then we'll open the floor for questions and concerns."

As he launched into the briefing, Hadler could feel the weight of each decision and its impact on his crew. This meeting would set the tone for the next phase of their mission, and he was determined to manage it with the clarity and focus that had earned him the respect of his team.

Captain Hadler began the briefing with a clear and focused tone, addressing his team with the confidence that came from years of navigating complex situations.

"Alright, everyone, let's dive into the details. We've secured a contract for a cargo run to Cassar Leinna mining station. The primary cargo will consist of essential supplies and equipment for the mining operations. We need to make the delivery within the next two weeks."

He paused to ensure everyone was following along and then continued. "We have some spare capacity—about 15 tons—that we can use to maximize our earnings. I'm considering two options: adding more mining tools and spare parts, or transporting delicate scientific equipment.

The mining tools and parts are straightforward and align with our current cargo. The scientific equipment offers higher payment but requires careful handling.”

The room buzzed with murmured comments and the occasional nod of understanding. Hadler looked around, noting the expressions of the department heads.

Chief Engineer Eddie spoke up first, his tone cautious. “Handling delicate scientific equipment is no small feat. What kind of modifications or preparations will we need to make to ensure its safe transport?”

Hadler nodded. “Good question. We’ll need to use some of our cargo racks for secure containment. The equipment needs to be stabilized and insulated to prevent any damage. We’ll also have to modify the storage areas to accommodate its fragility.”

At this point, the Security Chief, a grizzled veteran with a no-nonsense attitude, interjected with a grumble. “Captain, I’ve heard about this delicate cargo. You do realize that part of my ammo racks will be repurposed for this stuff? We’re going to have to be extra cautious with our handling. I don’t want my gunners risking their safety or the safety of the ship just because we’re dealing with this equipment.”

Hadler raised an eyebrow but maintained his composure. “I understand your concerns. I’ll ensure we implement additional safety protocols and brief the gunners thoroughly. I know it’s a bit of a squeeze, but we’ll make it work.”

The Comm Officer, Sydney, piped up next, his voice slightly anxious. “What about our communication equipment? If we’re carrying high-tech scientific gear, will there be any interference or risk of signal issues?”

Hadler glanced at the communications setup. “We’ll need to conduct a thorough check to ensure that the scientific equipment doesn’t interfere with our systems. I’ll coordinate with you to perform a full diagnostics before we depart.”

The Logistics Officer, a meticulous individual with a knack for detail, raised a hand. “Captain, considering the changes in our cargo, should we adjust our route or plan additional stops? We need to account for any potential delays or additional requirements.”

Hadler nodded, noting the importance of the question. “We’ll review the route and make any necessary adjustments. I’ll also factor in potential delays and ensure we have contingency plans in place.”

The Operations Manager, who was responsible for the day-to-day functioning of the ship, spoke up. “We should also consider the impact on our current workload and crew schedules. With the additional cargo and modifications, we might need to reassign some tasks or adjust shift patterns.”

“Absolutely,” Hadler agreed. “I’ll work on a revised schedule and ensure that everyone is briefed on their new responsibilities. We’ll make sure the adjustments don’t disrupt our operations.”

As each department head voiced their concerns, Hadler addressed them methodically, ensuring that all potential issues were acknowledged and planned for. The meeting continued with detailed discussions on the implementation of safety measures, adjustments to the ship’s systems, and coordination between departments.

Once all concerns were addressed and the team had a clear understanding of their roles and responsibilities, Hadler concluded the meeting. “Thank you all for your input. We’ve got a lot of work ahead, but I’m confident we can handle it. Let’s stay focused and make sure everything is ready before we depart. I’ll follow up with individual departments for any further details. Dismissed.”

The department heads began to disperse, each carrying a mix of relief and determination. Captain Hadler knew the road ahead would be challenging, but with his team’s support and the detailed planning now in place, he felt ready to tackle whatever lay ahead.

As Captain Hadler turned in for the night, he carried a mix of confidence and lingering concern. His crew was more than capable of handling the challenges that lay ahead, and he trusted their skills and dedication. However, the specter of delayed or missing payments loomed over him, a familiar shadow that never quite faded.

He reflected on his choice of mission. By opting for a cargo run involving essential supplies—specifically, food—he had minimized the risk of being stiffed. People needed food, and they needed it regularly. That necessity created a level of reliability and commitment that was less likely to falter, making it a safer bet compared to other, more volatile contracts. After all, a reliable food supply was something they’d likely want to secure again in the future, reducing the chance of getting shortchanged.

The old Earth term “milk run” had stuck for a reason, even in the icy expanse of Europa. It was a term that signified a regular, dependable route—one that promised consistent returns and less risk of corporate shenanigans. As he settled into his bunk, Hadler felt a sense of reassurance in his decision. It wasn’t glamorous or high-stakes, but it was practical and safe—a decision he hoped would keep his crew fed, his ship in good order, and himself from facing another corporate hassle.

That night, Captain Hadler’s dreams wove together the familiar textures of nostalgia and the turbulent currents of his present life. The haze of his sleep was punctuated by a static that seemed to blend with the distant, rhythmic thrumming of the sea. Sunlit beaches from his youth shimmered at the edges of his dreams, a stark contrast to the cold, metallic confines of his current reality.

In these dreams, he found himself transported back to simpler times. He was a young boy again, standing on a beach with the sun warming his face. His father was nearby, guiding him through the excitement of a new fascination: submarines. Hadler’s small hands gripped the tiny

remote control of a miniature, remote-controlled submarine. The little contraption, equipped with a modest camera and a tiny RV propeller, bobbed through the waves.

As the dream unfolded, he watched through the remote's feed—a view of surf and seaweed, with the propeller blades struggling to navigate through the debris. It was a simple joy, watching the small submarine chug along, its tiny camera sending back a signal of the underwater world, distorted by seaweed and the occasional splash.

The dream was a patchwork of these peaceful moments, contrasting sharply with the reality of his life now. It reminded him of his early fascination with submarines, a passion that had grown from the innocent play of childhood to the serious business of commanding a vessel. The memories were a balm, offering comfort amidst the stress of his current responsibilities, a reminder of where it all began and the journey he had traveled since those sunlit days on the beach.

Captain Hadler awoke abruptly to the jarring sound of the cabin's O2 alarm, a shrill reminder that even in the quiet of night, the ship's systems were ever vigilant. With a groggy motion, he reached out and slapped the bedside comm switch, connecting him directly to the bridge.

"Status report," he barked, his voice rough and disheveled from a night of restless sleep. The call was answered by Sarah, the morning watch officer, whose voice was tinged with the sort of distracted confusion that often accompanies an early shift.

"Sir, umm, it's already been reported as a false alarm," Sarah stammered, her tone apologetic and somewhat uncertain.

The captain, still half-asleep and not in the mood for any more drama, responded with a gruff, "Can you get the engineer of the watch to suppress the alarm, then, please?"

"On it, Captain," came Sarah's swift reply, and the call was cut off.

As Hadler sank back into his bed, he could hear the alarm's insistent wail gradually fading into a sad, declining squeal before finally falling silent. The air conditioning vents, operating sporadically, suggested a malfunction somewhere in the ship's extensive ductwork—a problem he was all too familiar with. The morning engineering crew was likely already deep into troubleshooting yet another series of electrical shorts.

Despite his irritation at the disrupted sleep, Hadler took a moment to appreciate the routine of it all. These alarms, these technical glitches, were a testament to the ship's ceaseless operation and the ongoing challenges of life aboard. Even in his half-dazed state, he knew the crew would handle it, as they always did. He closed his eyes again, hoping for a few more minutes of rest before the day's duties began in earnest.

Bleary-eyed and groggy from another round of interrupted sleep, Captain Hadler gave up on the futile pursuit of further slumber and decided to embrace the inevitable. He dragged himself out of bed and shuffled over to his personal coffee machine—a contraption that, if he were honest,

probably had more in common with caffeinated synthace than actual coffee. Still, there was something almost comforting in the routine. The packet of instant coffee tore open with that reliable, reassuring crinkle, and the smell that wafted through the cabin was a small, cherished pleasure.

Hadler allowed himself a few moments of indulgence, savoring the smell and the solitude of his captain's quarters. As he sipped the steaming brew, he grumbled to himself about the sorry state of his "coffee," but he couldn't deny the ritual's appeal. It was his little slice of luxury amid the chaos of running a submarine, a private reserve of pseudo-coffee that was just for him.

Once he'd managed to choke down a few more sips of his not-quite-coffee, he embarked on the task of making himself presentable. The captain's head smashed into his compact bathroom—barely bigger than a closet—was a testament to the luxury he enjoyed. It was a stark reminder of how far he'd come. Some submarines didn't even have such accommodations, and he was quite glad for the relative comfort of the Suther-class.

The Suther-class had its perks, and it was no accident that it kept him and his crew relatively happy. Its spacious crew compartments, sizable galley, hydroponics bay, and well-equipped engineering bay were a far cry from the cramped, mold-infested ships he'd seen. The air ducts, accessible from the hallways rather than embedded in the walls, meant that half the ship didn't smell like a forgotten swamp. The ship's design also included a substantial weapons and sonar platform, allowing it to defend against Europa's native nasties and any would-be pirates.

Hadler knew that the Suther-class's amenities were part of the reason why dock workers practically fought to get a chance to be recruited by a Suther-class captain. The ship's own bar was another coveted feature, a nod to the fact that even in the depths of space, a little bit of comfort went a long way. He was amazed he'd managed to fit so many crew members aboard, all while keeping things relatively clean and professional. It wasn't just about space; it was about making sure everyone felt they had a decent place to call their own, reducing the risk of staff jumping ship—or at least keeping them from grumbling too loudly about their cramped quarters.

Captain Hadler had just finished his morning ablutions when he heard the familiar, firm but polite knock on his door. It was the signal that the morning watch engineer was here to give her report on the early alarm that had pulled him from his restless slumber. With a resigned sigh, he cleared his throat and issued the customary invitation.

"Come in."

The door creaked open, and in stepped the morning watch engineer—a young woman whose bleary eyes and disheveled appearance spoke volumes about her hectic start to the day. Her uniform was streaked with smudges of grease and soot, evidence of her early morning battle with the submarine's temperamental electrical system. She carried a small, hastily written report, and her posture suggested a mix of nervousness and determination.

"Morning, Captain," she began, her voice almost squeaking as she tried to muster professionalism despite her evident exhaustion. "I've got the report on the alarm."

Hadler nodded, motioning for her to proceed. "Go ahead. What's the situation?"

The young engineer took a deep breath and began. "Well, Captain, the alarm was triggered by an electrical short in the ventilation system. We traced the fault to a section of ductwork where some wiring had become exposed and started shorting out due to moisture accumulation. It was one of those classic cases where the problem was hidden until it caused a bit of chaos."

Hadler raised an eyebrow, clearly unimpressed but listening intently. "And?"

"The good news is that we managed to isolate the fault quickly. The team had to crawl through a fair bit of ducting, but we've repaired the exposed wiring and replaced the damaged insulation. We used a combination of wire, duct tape, and sealants to fix the immediate problem."

She shuffled through her report, which was a mix of handwritten notes and scribbles. "Here's a summary of the repairs: we patched the faulty wiring and sealed up the ducts to prevent any more moisture issues. The sealant should hold for now, but we'll need to keep an eye on it. We've also done a quick check of the system to make sure everything is running smoothly."

Hadler took the report and skimmed through the details. "And the current stock of materials?"

"Ah, right," she continued, her voice regaining a bit of steadiness. "We're a bit low on wire and sealants. I've included a request for resupply in the report. The duct tape's holding up okay for now, but we should consider getting more if we keep having these issues. I've also noted a few other supplies that are getting low, just to keep us ahead of any further problems."

Hadler nodded thoughtfully, though he couldn't completely suppress a hint of frustration.

"Thanks for the update. I'll review the stock request and make sure we get what we need. Keep me posted if there are any more issues or if you need additional support."

The engineer looked visibly relieved, her posture relaxing slightly. "Yes, Captain. I'll keep you informed. Thank you."

With that, she turned and left, her footsteps echoing down the corridor as she headed back to her duties. Hadler stared at the report for a moment, reflecting on the constant challenges of maintaining a submarine. Despite the inconveniences and the occasional chaotic start to his day, he knew that the crew's dedication and resilience were what kept the Suther-class running smoothly.

Hadler decided it was time to take over the midday watch and give Ensign Halverson a break. He dialed up to the bridge, the familiar static of the communication system filling his ears as he waited for the response.

"Bridge, this is Captain Hadler," he announced, his voice firm and authoritative despite his earlier grogginess. "I'll be up shortly to take over the midday watch."

Ensign Halverson's bright-eyed enthusiasm came through clearly over the comms. "Aye, Captain. I'll have everything prepared for your arrival."

Halverson was a promising young officer, and Hadler had been keeping a close eye on him for some time. At 30, Halverson was already highly placed and technically in charge of the boat's overall operations, though he was outranked by several of the department heads. As a key player in the command track, Halverson was third in the indirect line of command, positioned for future leadership roles.

Hadler appreciated Halverson's energy and dedication. The young ensign was on the fast track to eventually take over his position, and the captain had been deliberately shaping his career path with that in mind. For now, Halverson's bright-eyed approach was a welcome contrast to the more seasoned, often jaded crew members.

As Hadler prepared to head to the bridge, he thought about the day ahead. The midday watch would involve not just overseeing the operations but also catching up on any ongoing issues and ensuring that everything was running smoothly. He hoped that Halverson's report would reflect a well-managed shift and that the ship would continue its operations without further hitches.

With a last glance at the report from the morning engineer and a final sip of his questionable coffee, Hadler made his way to the bridge. The Suther-class submarine, with its blend of practical amenities and defensive capabilities, was a well-oiled machine in many ways, thanks in no small part to the efforts of crew members like Halverson.

Captain Hadler quietly enjoyed his short journey from his cabin to the bridge, moving through the ship's single vertical access shaft. This pathway, though a logistical challenge for a ship of this size, had become one of his favorite parts of the daily routine. Its walls, worn by countless hands and feet, were a testament to the constant movement of his crew, but they also provided him with a unique vantage point.

Every day, the shaft hummed with activity, crew members traveling up and down on their various tasks. The conversations drifting through the corridor weren't just idle chatter—they were his unofficial reports, offering a pulse on the crew's collective mood. Was there laughter? Frustration? Quiet determination? Each voice, each tone, gave him insight into how well his team was holding up under the strain of their mission.

Today, he caught snippets of conversation—discussions about maintenance, some light-hearted banter about ration quality, and a few mumbles about the long shifts ahead. Nothing out of the ordinary, but all useful for Hadler's mental inventory. With every rung of the ladder, he got a clearer sense of how his ship was running, both mechanically and emotionally.

As he neared the bridge, he braced himself for another day at the helm, feeling a small sense of reassurance from the chatter below. His crew was holding up, and that meant they were ready to face whatever lay ahead.

Captain Hadler stepped onto the bridge, greeting Ensign Halverson with a nod. Halverson, ever the diligent officer, quickly ran through the night's report. They were still docked, and a few crew members were still enjoying their final hours of shore leave, but they were slated to return soon. Halverson mentioned a message left by a dockworker—cargo unloading for their contract had begun at a nearby warehouse, and it wouldn't be long before they needed to coordinate with the dockmaster for unloading teams.

There was also an incident in the galley. One of the assistant chefs had attempted something ambitious—perhaps too ambitious. Whatever culinary experiment they'd tried had gone up in flames. Fortunately, the fire had been minor, causing no damage beyond the loss of some precious cuts of meat. The head chef had already handled the situation, berating the hapless assistant chef appropriately.

Captain Hadler grimaced at the mention of the meat. Earthside protein rations had run out ages ago, and Europa's colonists had long since adapted to the local fare. The coalition's universal endorsement of locally sourced protein from Europa's flora and fauna had been practical, but it also introduced a variety of flavors that had taken years for his Earth-trained palate to adjust to. Hydroponic farms supplemented their diets with substitutes for almost everything, but the taste could range from tolerable to... downright alien.

Hadler sighed inwardly. He missed the simplicity of an Earthside steak, something impossible to find this far from home. Instead, his crew had to settle for creative variations of European algae burgers and faux-fish fillets. He shook his head, forcing the thought away—food was food, and out here, you took what you could get. At least the galley fire hadn't caused any real damage, but he made a mental note to keep an eye on that assistant chef.

Captain Hadler's hopes for a calm day of negotiations evaporated as the security station to his right lit up with an incoming communication from dockside. Something was amiss. He moved over to stand above the security watchman, who quickly cycled through a number of security feeds until he found an external dock view. What he saw was far from routine.

A small, four-wheeled cart—a common dockside vehicle, akin to a golf cart—whirled through the gap between warehouses. A group of familiar uniforms clung to the vehicle, recognizable as his missing crew members on leave. But there was something far more concerning: an individual slumped among them, clad in dark brown clothes, with a bright red stain spreading across their side. The telltale sound of gunfire echoed through the external mics, sending a cold chill down Hadler's spine.

The cart was approaching fast, weaving down the dock gangways at breakneck speed, pursued by well-dressed men emerging from an alleyway—men in suits, no less, who opened fire on the fleeing vehicle. Hadler cursed under his breath. These were no ordinary dockside thugs. As soon as the men realized they were in full public view, they retreated back into the alley,

disappearing as quickly as they had emerged. But the damage was done; his crew was barreling towards the submarine, their wounded passenger in tow.

The cart screeched to a halt at the sub dock, and the captain quickly called back to the security watchman. "Get the security team to the docking ring—now! I don't know who that is, but they're not getting on my ship without some answers."

Unfortunately, his order was a moment too late. The unidentified man had already crossed the docking clamp with his crew. There wasn't enough time for the security team to intercept them before they reached the dive compartment just below the docking ring.

Hadler's mind raced. Whoever this man was, he had already brought trouble to their doorstep. The captain had to act quickly. He turned to the bridge crew, his voice steady but firm. "Lock down access to the main compartments. I want security on high alert until we get this sorted out. And someone, get me a read on who the hell that is and why he's bleeding all over my ship."

The security team quickly rounded up the returning crewmates and their unexpected guest, a man who introduced himself as Comrade Vlastov. His accent was unmistakably Slavic, with a rough edge that pegged him as a member of the separatists—an affiliation that immediately set Captain Hadler on edge. From his position in the hallway just outside the dive compartment, Hadler glared at the ragtag group, his arms folded across his chest.

"Alright," he barked, "which one of you thought *this* was a good idea?"

After a tense pause, one of the senior engineers, Kevin, raised his hand sheepishly. The look Hadler shot him could've melted steel.

"Kevin, you're coming with me," Hadler growled, singling him out. "We're gonna have a talk in the cabin. The rest of you, stay here. Don't move."

Kevin, looking like he'd rather be anywhere else, nodded and followed the captain. The remaining crewmates shifted uncomfortably, clearly aware they were in deep trouble. Hadler turned to the nearest security officer, Alvarez, and issued his next orders with the same no-nonsense tone.

"Alvarez, go get Dr. Chirde. Make sure Vlastov's not about to bleed out all over my sub, but he's not coming any further onboard until I say so."

Alvarez gave a crisp nod and headed off to find the ship's doctor. Meanwhile, Hadler led Kevin down the corridor, his mind already racing through the conversation they were about to have.

Separatists meant trouble, and the last thing he needed was to get entangled in their conflicts. But first, he needed answers. How had Kevin and the others gotten mixed up with this man, and what had they brought aboard with them—other than a heap of problems?

Captain Hadler led the way through the narrow corridors of the sub, the silence between him and Kevin growing heavier with each step. Kevin's nervous glances went unnoticed, or at least unacknowledged by the captain, who kept his pace steady and his face unreadable. The tension was thick, and Kevin could feel it settling in his stomach like a lead weight.

Once inside the captain's cabin, Hadler closed the door behind them with a deliberate click, sealing the world out. He didn't speak, not immediately. Instead, he moved to his desk, sat down, and took a long, measured breath—letting out a sigh that carried the weight of someone who had seen too much nonsense for one lifetime. Finally, he gestured toward the seat across from him with a firm, almost resigned wave. The silent command was clear: *Start talking.*

Kevin hesitated for a moment, rubbing the back of his neck before awkwardly lowering himself into the chair. He knew he was deep in it, and the captain's unrelenting gaze only made it worse. There was no use beating around the bush, so he dove right in, his words spilling out in a rushed, nervous explanation.

"Captain, I... I didn't plan on bringing him back here, I swear. It all just happened so fast." He took a deep breath, trying to gather his thoughts. "We were down by the docks, just having a drink after getting some parts for the sub, y'know? Then this guy, Vlastov, he stumbles out of an alley, bleeding all over the place. Looked like he was in real bad shape, and then these guys started shooting. We didn't even have time to think, Captain—they were firing at anything that moved, and Vlastov, he... he practically begged us to help him."

Kevin shifted uncomfortably in his chair, his eyes darting to the captain's expressionless face. "I know, I know, it was stupid, but he said if we left him, they'd kill him for sure. Said he had information, something valuable... something that could get us all out of a jam if we needed it. I thought... maybe it was worth the risk. We're not exactly flush with credits, and if he's got something worth trading, it could help."

He looked down at his hands, which were now balled into fists on his lap. "I didn't mean to drag this kind of trouble aboard, Captain. But... he said he'd make it worth our while. He seemed desperate."

Hadler leaned back in his chair, his fingers drumming thoughtfully on the armrest. Kevin's explanation wasn't exactly surprising—he'd seen plenty of crewmembers make split-second decisions under pressure, and not all of them were good ones. But bringing a wounded separatist onboard? That was a special kind of trouble, and it had the potential to sink them all in more ways than one.

The captain's eyes narrowed as he considered his options. "Kevin," he said slowly, his voice low and measured, "you've just brought a bleeding, wanted man onto this sub, in the middle of a

gunfight, no less. Do you have any idea what kind of mess we're in now? Separatists don't play nice, and neither do the people hunting them."

Kevin nodded miserably. "I know, Captain. I screwed up. But... what do we do now?"

Hadler sighed again, this time with the weight of a decision settling on his shoulders. He wasn't about to let this situation spiral out of control, but he also wasn't about to abandon someone in need—even if that someone was a separatist with more baggage than the sub could hold.

"We're going to figure this out," he said finally, his tone resolute. "But first, we need to find out exactly what kind of information Vlastov has—and whether it's worth the trouble you've brought to our doorstep. Until then, he stays under lock and key, and you, Kevin, are going to help keep an eye on him. We're not taking any chances."

Kevin nodded, relief mingling with anxiety as he realized he wasn't about to be tossed out an airlock. Not yet, at least.

Hadler stood up, his face set in determination. "Let's go see what this 'comrade' of yours has to say."

Captain Hadler took a slow, deliberate sip of his coffee as Comrade Vlastov was deposited in front of him. The man looked like he'd been through the wringer—his head and chest swathed in bandages that screamed "bare minimum effort" courtesy of Dr. Chirde. The doctor's handiwork was unmistakable, with that familiar air of "you're not my problem, so don't expect miracles." Hadler recognized the look immediately, a clear sign that Vlastov had been patched up just enough to function but would have to grit his teeth through the pain. The captain made a mental note to have a word with the good doctor later about the bare-bones approach.

Vlastov grimaced as he sat down, clearly in discomfort, but Hadler wasn't exactly feeling sympathetic. This was a mess that had landed right in his lap, and he wasn't about to let it fester. As he settled behind his desk, his coffee now serving as a buffer between him and the headache that this situation was quickly becoming, he introduced himself with a curt nod. Vlastov, for his part, seemed to be trying to balance desperation with a thin veneer of composure as he launched into his tale.

The separatist claimed he had been minding his own business—just another day of skulking around, no doubt—when he'd been accosted by some syndicate thugs. Apparently, his network of shady acquaintances, including some bartenders and local patrons, had seen what went down and, in a stroke of bad luck for Hadler, his crew had been nearby when the bullets started flying. Vlastov offered what he thought was a sweet deal: safe passage out of the station in exchange for a sizeable fee and, as a bonus, the location of some arms and munitions they could pick up along the way.

Hadler let him finish without interruption, carefully placing his coffee cup down as he processed the proposal. Vlastov, hopeful eyes scanning the captain for any sign of agreement, looked like

he was waiting for a lifeline. But the only thing Hadler was about to throw him was a one-way ticket to someone else's problem.

"Nice story," Hadler finally said, his voice calm but with an edge of finality. "But we're not running a charity, and we're sure as hell not running guns for separatists. You're not getting a free ride out of here, comrade. What you *are* getting is a short stay in our brig while I call the dock chief to come pick you up. We're not interested in your fee, your guns, or your syndicate problems."

With that, he motioned to the security head, who was standing just outside the door. "Take him to the brig," he ordered, "and make sure he's comfortable enough to wait for his ride."

As Vlastov was escorted out, Hadler turned to his security chief with a glare that could melt steel. "This is a bucket of worms I don't want any part of. Call the dock chief and tell him we've got a fugitive who needs picking up. We're not getting tangled up in separatist business or anyone else's dirty work. Understood?"

The security head, a seasoned officer who'd seen more than his fair share of bad decisions from both crew and passengers, nodded quickly. "Understood, Captain. I'll make the call."

Hadler watched as the door closed behind them, leaving him alone with his coffee and the creeping feeling that this whole incident was only a taste of what Europa had in store for them. Taking another sip, he allowed himself a brief moment of contemplation. He'd dealt with shady deals, desperate stowaways, and corporate trickery before, but he always knew when to steer clear of a bad storm.

This was one of those times.

Captain Hadler took a long, deliberate sip of his coffee, savoring the warmth and bitterness that seemed to ground him amid the chaos. Thoughts about Europa and the fractured, unstable state of things here swirled through his mind. It wasn't the first time he'd witnessed a slice of this chaos—hell, Europa had a way of serving it up in spades—but that didn't make it any easier to swallow. The events of the morning had stolen hours of his time, and he could feel the weight of them pressing down on him.

With a slow, steady breath, he pulled himself together. This wasn't his first time navigating tricky waters, and it wouldn't be the last. He had a ship to run, and the bridge wouldn't wait. He straightened his uniform, drained the last of the coffee, and made his way back to the bridge. As he stepped through the familiar corridors, he could sense the shift in the atmosphere. Conversations hushed as he passed, and there was an unspoken tension among the crew. They were on edge, unsure of how to process what had just gone down.

Hadler couldn't blame them. It wasn't every day that gunfire and strange separatists found their way onto the ship. But he hoped they'd learn from this. Dragging onboard random strangers involved in shootouts wasn't just reckless; it could spell disaster for the entire crew. Throwing their lot in with the separatists? That wasn't going to end well for anyone, least of all their financial situation.

Arriving on the bridge, he didn't waste any time. He locked eyes with Sidney, the comms officer, and gave a firm nod. "Call up the dockmaster," he ordered, his voice steady and authoritative. "Let's get that cargo offloaded. Business as usual."

Sidney nodded, quickly dialing up the dockmaster on the comms line. At the same time, Hadler's security chief was on a separate line, phoning the local police department. The bridge hummed with overlapping conversations, the distinct sound of two different realities unfolding side by side. Dockworkers on one line, coordinating cargo unloading as if the morning had been entirely routine. On the other, a cautious conversation with the authorities, informing them of the "guest" currently sitting in their brig.

Hadler didn't care who overheard what. He wasn't interested in playing cloak-and-dagger games or keeping things under wraps. He wanted it known—loud and clear—that his sub wasn't getting tangled up in local turf wars, separatist movements, or whatever else Europa wanted to throw their way.

The calls proceeded smoothly enough, though there was no mistaking the undercurrent of tension on the bridge. Dockmaster crews began coordinating the cargo transfer, and the police were alerted to pick up their fugitive. For Hadler, it was just another day of keeping the ship, and his crew, afloat in a sea of chaos.

With both conversations winding down, Hadler turned his gaze out over the bridge. "We've got cargo to move, people. Let's get it done," he said, his voice cutting through the lingering tension. For now, at least, they could focus on something tangible. The dockmaster's voice droned on over the comms, and Hadler allowed himself a small smirk. Maybe today, the only problems they'd face would be logistical. And that was just fine with him.

As the local authorities arrived at the docking ring to retrieve their so-called "fugitive," Captain Hadler watched the exchange with a measured gaze. The officers moved with deliberate efficiency, escorting the wounded separatist off the ship, and Hadler felt a quiet relief as they led the man away. Good riddance, he thought. He had enough on his plate without getting involved in local political nonsense.

He turned to Dario, his head of security, who was standing nearby, arms crossed, watching the handoff with his usual calm demeanor. Dario had always been an odd mix of laid-back and ruthlessly efficient—a combination Hadler had come to appreciate over the years. The man handled security with a cold, clinical precision, approaching his duties with a logic that bordered on merciless. And yet, despite that, Dario wasn't rigid. He followed orders, even when he didn't entirely agree with them, which was more than Hadler could say for some of his past security chiefs.

Hadler nodded to Dario, signaling for a conversation. The two stepped to the side, out of earshot of the rest of the crew.

“Handled that well enough,” Hadler said, his tone neutral but with an underlying note of approval. “Good call getting the local authorities involved. I don’t want this separatist business anywhere near my ship.”

Dario gave a curt nod, his expression as stoic as ever. “Wasn’t exactly keen on housing him in the brig, either. Figured it was best to pass the problem off before it became ours.”

“Smart move,” Hadler agreed, glancing toward the docking bay as the authorities disappeared into the station’s corridors with their prisoner. “I don’t need more complications, and separatists tend to bring those in spades.”

Dario’s eyes narrowed slightly, a flicker of concern crossing his usually unreadable face. “You think this is going to come back on us? Even with him out of our hands, we were still involved. And his friends—whoever they are—might not take kindly to us handing him over.”

Hadler let out a long breath, considering the possibility. “Maybe. But we’re not sticking around long enough to find out. Once that cargo is loaded, we’re off this rock. As far as I’m concerned, we had no choice but to follow protocol. It’s not like we’re harboring criminals.”

Dario nodded again, seemingly satisfied with the captain’s reasoning. “Fair enough. I’ll keep an eye on things until we’re clear.”

Hadler clapped him on the shoulder, a rare gesture of camaraderie. “Do that. And let’s hope that’s the last of our surprises for the day.”

With that, Dario returned to his duties, slipping back into his role with his characteristic blend of relaxed intensity. Hadler watched him go, appreciating the quiet competence the man brought to the job. There were times when he disagreed with Dario’s blunt, no-nonsense approach, but moments like these reminded him why he kept the man around. Security was a job that required a steady hand and a mind for logic—both of which Dario had in abundance.

As the day wore on, Hadler couldn’t shake the nagging feeling that this whole separatist incident was just the beginning of something more complicated. But for now, he focused on the task at hand: getting the cargo on board and making sure they were ready to shove off. Whatever was brewing on Europa, he intended to be long gone before it boiled over.

It took three full shifts of crew rotations—yes, three entire, mind-numbing shifts—to load every last crate of their precious cargo. Captain Hadler watched the process from afar, sipping what was probably his tenth cup of caffeinated synth sludge, which barely passed for coffee. He knew it would take just as long to unload everything on the other end, which meant more bleary-eyed crewmates trudging through the ship’s corridors, hauling boxes, and complaining about back pain that made them feel ten years older than they were. He couldn’t blame them; the loading process was about as exciting as watching rust grow on a bulkhead.

Still, he had to admit, the whole ordeal was running relatively smoothly. They had a few extra days built into the schedule, just enough wiggle room to deal with whatever nonsense might

crop up between now and their destination. Engine failure? Unexplained bilge issues? Maybe even a surprise encounter with a local sea monster? Who knew? But whatever it was, Hadler was determined to be prepared. He always insisted on adding those extra days of transit time, just in case something went wrong—and something always went wrong.

Of course, the contract agents never liked that. They were all about fast deliveries and rush jobs. Get the cargo there yesterday, and if you can't, why are you even in this business? They wanted their goods delivered with the speed of light, as if his crew could somehow defy the laws of physics and teleport everything to its destination. And sure, Hadler could've played along, taking those lucrative contracts that demanded impossible speeds and tight schedules. But he preferred to live long enough to see his paychecks, so he always built in that buffer time, even if it meant taking a pay cut.

There was a twisted logic to it: better to make a little less and survive to take another contract than rush a job and end up dead in the water—literally. Besides, the extra time gave his crew a fighting chance against whatever random calamity might pop up along the way. You know, the usual: electrical shorts, hull breaches, mutinous seaweed (yes, that was a thing once), or that one time an entire cargo hold decided to flood itself for no discernible reason. The joys of deep-sea spacefaring never ceased to amaze.

As the final crates were secured and the crew stumbled back to their quarters for some much-needed rest, Hadler allowed himself a rare moment of optimism. Maybe, just maybe, this trip would be one of those rare milk runs where nothing went wrong, and they could offload the cargo without having to patch up the ship halfway through. But then again, this was Europa, and if there was one thing he'd learned in all his years of running these routes, it was that optimism was best kept in check.

For now, though, the cargo was on board, the ship was ready, and they had a few extra days in their pocket. And that, Hadler thought with a smirk, was as close to perfect as things ever got out here.

It was their last night at dock—a night that, as far as Captain Hadler was concerned, was always a delicate dance between final preparations and everyone sneaking in a last moment of shore leave. The ship was alive with the hum of last-minute activity: the crew was stowing gear, packing away supplies, and tucking those last-second purchases into every nook and cranny. The chef and his team, as usual, were the last ones hauling crates up the gangway, this time laden with fresh vegetables from the local hydroponics bay. Fresh food was a treasure on Europa, practically worth its weight in gold—especially for a submarine crew used to choking down rehydrated meals. Buying it right before departure was the only way to ensure the produce lasted as long as possible.

By now, the ship's routines were well-practiced, a choreography that had been honed over countless voyages. The crew chiefs and department heads reported in, ticking off their headcounts and confirming that every soul was aboard. Captain Hadler had made it clear long ago: no matter how efficient the loading process was, they always spent one final night in port. It

gave everyone a chance to rest, do some last-minute stocking up, and maybe, just maybe, mentally prepare for the days ahead. Sure, it might mean spending a bit more time docked, but it was worth it. A well-rested, well-supplied crew was a crew less likely to lose their minds halfway through the voyage. And with that, the ship's external ports were sealed up, the vessel still drawing on dockside power, but everything was ready for a morning departure.

Hadler, knowing this routine like the back of his hand, allowed himself to indulge in one of the Suther-class's more appreciated luxuries: the ship's bar. With most of the crew either sleeping or wrapping up their own preparations, the captain and his department heads gathered for what had become a tradition on their last night in port. The bar wasn't much—a small space with a few tables, a handful of booths, and a well-worn bar—but it was theirs. The music was already thumping in the background, just loud enough to give the place a bit of energy but not so loud that it drowned out conversation. The chatter of the officers was a comfortable hum, punctuated by the clink of ice in glasses and the occasional laugh.

As Hadler stepped into the room, the crew's attention shifted briefly to him. Nods of acknowledgment and murmurs of "Captain" followed him as he made his way to the end of the bar, where Julio, the ship's bartender, was already waiting. With a practiced motion, Julio poured what they all referred to as Hadler's "favorite tequila," though in reality, reliable supplies of alcohol were as unpredictable as anything else on Europa. Whatever it was, it did the job, and that's all Hadler cared about.

Taking the glass from Julio, Hadler raised it high, glancing around at his officers, who were now watching him expectantly. He downed the drink in one swift motion, then slammed the glass onto the bar with a satisfying thud. A cheer went up from the crew, and with that, he launched into his speech—a mix of encouragement, last-minute reminders, and a few well-timed jokes to lighten the mood.

He kept it short, as he always did. No point in dragging it out when everyone was itching to either relax or finish up their work. He spoke of their upcoming voyage, of the importance of staying sharp and sticking to routines, but also of celebrating the little victories along the way—like making it through another day with the engines still running and the ship still in one piece. He threw in a few mentions of upcoming birthdays, anniversaries, and milestones, knowing that those small personal acknowledgments went a long way in keeping morale up during long stretches at sea.

As he wrapped up, another round of drinks was poured, and the atmosphere in the bar shifted from one of quiet anticipation to one of camaraderie. This was their ritual—a moment of shared humanity before they plunged back into the mechanical, dangerous world of submarine life. Hadler allowed himself a moment to soak it all in, then slipped away from the bar, leaving his officers to their drinks and their conversations. Tomorrow, they would be underway, and who knew what challenges would greet them. But for tonight, they had each other, a few good drinks, and the comfort of knowing that they were as ready as they could be.

As the night wore on and the final preparations slipped into their practiced routine, the ship settled into a quiet rhythm. The graveyard shift took over, running through their checklist of last-minute tasks and making sure everything was in order for the morning's departure. The pneumatic ejection system, a marvel of modern maritime engineering, was key to their departure.

The pneumatic ejection system was essentially a sophisticated mechanism designed to detach submarines from their docking clamps and give them a gentle push away from the dock. When activated, high-pressure air is blasted through a series of carefully calibrated nozzles, which not only releases the docking clamps but also provides a slight boost of propulsion. This ensures the submarine has a smooth and controlled exit from the dock. It's a bit like a high-tech air cannon aimed at the ship's rear, with the added benefit of not requiring an entire battalion of dock workers to manually push the vessel out. The force from the pneumatic ejection helps to overcome the friction of the docking clamps and the often stubborn resistance of the vessel's hull sticking to the dock.

Naturally, the engineers always fretted over the strength of the docking clamps and the surrounding structural members. The additional stress from the pneumatic shunt could potentially cause unexpected issues in the dock's infrastructure. It's not uncommon for a rogue vibration or an unforeseen strain to trigger a cascade of problems, which is why they were always on edge during this part of the process.

This morning, however, seemed to be one of those rare occasions when everything went off without a hitch. The captain, settled into his routine, noted with satisfaction that there were no unexpected mid-morning oxygen alarms or alarming structural warnings as they disengaged from the dock. The pneumatic ejection system performed flawlessly, and the ship slipped away from the dock with a reassuring, almost anticlimactic ease.

With the vessel now clear of the dock, the captain eased the engines up to half speed. It was a deliberate choice—he didn't want to tax the electrical systems too much right at the start of the voyage. The passageways near the dock were relatively straightforward and well-documented, thanks to an array of sonar returns, flags, and markers that cluttered the local navigational aids. The navigation team could follow these markers with the ease of a well-trodden path, ensuring that they stayed on course without any hitches.

As the ship moved away, the harbormaster's customary farewell echoed over the speakers—an upbeat snippet of music that seemed to wish them well. It was a small but cherished tradition, adding a touch of humanity to the otherwise sterile environment of the docks. The captain listened to the tune with a wry smile, appreciating the small gestures that made the job just a bit more pleasant.

With the vessel now fully underway, Hadler felt a sense of relief. The immediate concerns of departure had passed smoothly, leaving him with the reassurance that, barring any unforeseen events, the rest of the voyage would likely follow suit. For now, all that remained was to keep a

steady course, monitor the systems, and ensure that the crew was ready for whatever lay ahead.

The ship maneuvered carefully into a tight passage, navigating one of the first significant challenges of the journey. The chart indicated a tricky sequence: a hard right followed immediately by a hard left. This would demand some serious torque from the rudder, which was the ship's primary tool for changing direction, especially given the tight confines.

The Suther-class submarine, with its advanced engineering, could handle tight turns, but the rudder's effectiveness was paramount. As the ship approached the right turn, the propulsion system worked overtime to redirect the vessel. The maneuver was a bit of a juggling act: the rudder did most of the heavy lifting, while the ship's own steering systems provided some assistance, though it was minimal compared to the adjustments made by the rudders.

As the ship executed the hard left turn, there was a noticeable shimmy throughout the structure. The vibrations were a bit unsettling, a reminder of the immense stress the ship's structural members were under. It wasn't long before a yellow warning light flashed on the control panel, indicating an issue with one of the left rear structural members. The alert was immediate, and the engineering team responded with their customary efficiency. They quickly reported to the bridge that they were sending a welding team to inspect and repair the problem.

Hadler couldn't help but feel a twinge of frustration. He hoped this would be the only hiccup on their voyage. The passageways ahead were notoriously poorly mapped, and the shifting ice of Europa made reliable navigation a gamble. Without the regular maintenance of icebreakers—massive and expensive vessels typically operated by the largest colonies—navigating these routes was always a challenge. Icebreakers, essential for maintaining the most vital cargo passages, were seldom used for the less critical routes, leaving many paths uncharted and treacherous.

The captain took a deep breath and reminded himself that they had planned for contingencies like this. The crew was well-trained and prepared for such issues, and their systems were designed to handle stress. As he observed the engineering team spring into action, Hadler hoped this would be the only snag and that the ship would glide smoothly through the remaining passages.

The crew continued their work, the welders busy with their repairs while the navigation team kept a close eye on the route. The ship's progress was steady, and despite the occasional vibration, everything seemed to be running relatively smoothly. The captain's focus shifted back to the journey ahead, mentally preparing for the challenges that lay in wait, while hoping that the rest of the voyage would be less eventful.

As Hadler settled into his chair on the bridge, the monotone hum of damage control reports filled the air—a symphony of bureaucratic jargon and technical mumbo-jumbo. He leaned back, listening to the damage control team explain the latest hiccup in their flawless voyage. It turned out that one of their prized structural members, LT1 078, had suffered some minor buckling,

along with its adjoining structural members. The flood compartments weren't exactly having a party, but they were feeling a little cramped.

The damage, though not ideal, was like the ship's version of a bad hair day: inconvenient but manageable. The structural members were still in one piece, just slightly less perfect than they'd been moments before. Fortunately, the damage was entirely cosmetic, a bit like a dent in a new car. The good news was that the repairs could be handled from the inside, sparing them the glamorous option of stopping the ship and doing a few underwater repairs.

The repair strategy involved a bit of inside-out patchwork. They'd need to temporarily flood the adjoining dive compartment—just a tiny splash of water to make things interesting—while a quick fix job would replace a few structural elements here and there. It was a delicate operation: empty the dive compartment, rebalance the ship, and pray that the delicate equilibrium didn't lead to a spontaneous ship-wide dance party.

The overall impact was negligible: a minor rise in the water level of other compartments would throw the ship's stability off by only a degree or two. In the grand scheme of things, it was like spilling a cup of coffee on a table: annoying but not a disaster.

So, with a sigh that spoke volumes of professional weariness, Hadler acknowledged the report. The ship wasn't going to win any awards for elegance, but it was still afloat and largely intact. The crew's efficiency was impressive, and their ability to turn a potential catastrophe into a minor inconvenience was nothing short of remarkable.

As the repair teams got to work, Hadler allowed himself a small, cynical smile. This was just another day in the life of a submarine captain, where the unexpected was the norm, and perfection was a distant dream. But with a crew like his, even the quirks of the ship could be managed with a mix of skill, sarcasm, and just a touch of patience.

The captain, having weathered a long and somewhat grueling day, huddled with the navigator and other department heads, immersed in the fine art of interpreting sonar readings and estimating the dimensions of the passageways ahead. It was one of those days where every blip on the sonar could mean anything from a harmless school of fish to something far more ominous, though thankfully, it seemed like the day's biggest threat was the occasional small fish making an appearance.

The voyage, despite its tension, was progressing smoothly. The captain found himself reflecting on Europa's quirky ecosystem, a marvel of adaptation and evolution that was far beyond the mundane confines of routine. It was an odd nostalgia to think back on how they had tried—and failed—to contain Earth's native sea life in aquariums and experimental growth tanks. The initial idea had been to keep a slice of Earth's underwater world intact for human consumption and comfort, but the universe, as it often does, had other plans.

The first few station disasters and collapses had made it clear that keeping Terran sea life confined was about as successful as trying to herd cats. The efforts to maintain Earth's deep-sea species in a contained environment had rapidly dissolved into a lesson in futility. Over time, as humans established their colonies on Europa, those same Earth-native deep-sea creatures had made an impressive escape into the alien waters.

The results were nothing short of evolutionary artistry. Terra's once-familiar sea creatures had morphed into something out of a science fiction novel. Fish that were once sleek and elegant had become lumpier, squatter versions of their former selves, sporting additional fins or peculiar growths. Corals and algae, once confined to their Earthly habitats, now bloomed and thrived in strange new forms. The deep-sea crabs and lobsters had adapted with surprising efficiency, almost as if they had been waiting for the opportunity to outdo their terrestrial cousins.

This new underwater world was a playground for submariners, who, despite the chaos above, were never in short supply of seafood. The bizarre and sometimes grotesque adaptations of familiar creatures had turned Europa into a seafood lover's paradise—or at least a submarine crew's dream.

As the captain reflected on these peculiarities, he couldn't help but marvel at the resilience of life. It had adapted, evolved, and thrived in ways no one could have predicted, creating an environment where even the smallest of fish could turn into a topic of profound contemplation amidst the hum of sonar readings and the daily grind of submarine life.

On the first day of the voyage, the ship's galley was abuzz with activity, the crew eagerly diving into the fresh fruits and vegetables that had been hurriedly loaded before departure. The captain, still in the throes of sorting out various shipboard matters, found himself sampling the day's bounty on the command deck.

He munched on what he swore were genuine blueberries, despite the packaging's insistence that they were some form of synthetic substitute. To be fair, if someone had told him these blueberries were harvested from the vacuum of space and processed by sentient robots, he might have believed it. But here he was, crunching away, and savoring the burst of flavor that somehow felt like a small victory over the dreariness of deep-space rations.

The galley had become a hub of activity, the crew making quick work of the fresh produce that had been carefully stowed for immediate consumption. The fresh salads, with their crisp, vibrant ingredients, were eagerly devoured. Anything that didn't have a long shelf life was rapidly consumed in a race against time, ensuring that nothing went to waste.

The blueberries in particular seemed to be a hit—or at least the captain was convinced they were authentic. As he chewed thoughtfully, he couldn't help but muse over the irony. After all, what could be more quintessentially human than an indulgent treat, even if it came with a side of existential questions about the nature of its authenticity? The idea of these blueberries, whether real or synthetic, was a small, comforting piece of normalcy in the vast and often impersonal expanse of space.

The crew was in high spirits, buoyed by the luxury of fresh ingredients that made their meals feel a bit more like home. For now, the simple pleasure of fresh produce and the camaraderie of shared meals served as a pleasant distraction from the endless, unchanging expanse outside the submarine's hull.

As the captain wrapped up his shift and prepared to hand over responsibilities to the night crew, he began his familiar trek from the bridge to his cabin. The journey was accompanied by the ever-present symphony of submarine life: the ominous clanging of a mechanic somewhere in the bowels of the vessel, diligently performing the daily maintenance required to keep everything running smoothly.

The rhythmic thumping and clanging of metal tools against metal were punctuated by the grumbling and occasional bursts of colorful language from the maintenance crew. They were hard at work, swapping out pump bearings and gears, ensuring that the pumps, fans, and various bits of mechanical machinery continued their tireless churn. Their voices, though often laced with frustration, were a comforting reminder of the ship's inner workings and the hands that kept it all from falling apart.

The captain took a moment to appreciate the irony of it all: while the vast, cold expanse of Europa loomed outside, inside the submarine was a bustling microcosm of human effort and ingenuity. The maintenance crew's constant battle against wear and tear was a crucial part of that effort. He could almost picture them down there, sweat-streaked and grim-faced, wrestling with stubborn machinery as if it were a living beast.

With a weary but satisfied sigh, he navigated the corridors, the soft hum of the ship's systems a background melody to his thoughts. The occasional spark from an exposed wire or the flicker of a failing light was a reminder of the constant, delicate balance required to keep the submarine in operational shape. Each minor malfunction or mechanical hiccup was just another hurdle to overcome, and the crew's ability to handle them was a testament to their skill and resilience.

The captain finally reached his cabin, the clamor of the maintenance crew fading into the background. He appreciated the rare moments of quiet that greeted him as he closed the door behind him. Here, in the solitude of his personal space, he could shed the weight of command, if only for a few hours, and settle in for what he hoped would be a restful night. The noise of the machinery, the grumbling of the mechanics, and the endless hum of the submarine would be just distant enough to allow him a few hours of peace before the cycle began anew.

The captain's dreams that night took him to grim, polluted shores of Ashfield, where the beaches were choked with garbage and filth—a stark contrast to the pristine visions of his youth. He remembered sitting in a lounge chair on the beach, casting his line into the churning waves, only to reel in a relentless tide of trash instead of fish. His father stood beside him, the scene marred by an eerie transformation: his father's mouth stretched wide, emitting a blaring siren's wail that echoed through the beachscape and jolted him awake.

In a blur of half-remembered dreams and harsh reality, the captain rolled over in his bed, clad in nothing but his nightshirt and boxers. The ship's alarm system had chosen this moment to blare out its incoming contacts alert, slicing through the remnants of his restless sleep. He slapped the comm switch with a swift, practiced motion.

"Status report!" he barked, his voice rough and groggy from disrupted sleep.

The response from the bridge came through, a mix of ruffled voices and clipped reports. Numbers, vectors, and strengths of the approaching contacts were read out with the urgency of seasoned professionals.

"Captain, we have multiple contacts approaching from the northeast. Distances are closing rapidly. Sonar indicates at least three distinct signatures, but there's interference making precise identification difficult. We're working on getting more accurate data."

The captain's mind raced, shaking off the last vestiges of sleep. The impending situation was rapidly shifting from the realm of dream-induced panic to real-world urgency. He quickly assessed the information relayed to him, his tactical mind snapping into focus. The threat, whatever it was, would need a swift and calculated response.

"Get me a detailed scan of those contacts. I want to know what we're dealing with before we make any moves. And get the damage control teams on standby, just in case."

The bridge crew sprang into action, their movements quick and efficient. The captain's sleep-worn brain began to clear as he focused on the task at hand, mentally shifting gears from the disquieting imagery of his dream to the pressing reality of their situation.

The captain shook himself awake and hastily donned his uniform, his mind racing to keep up with the blaring alarms and the urgency of the situation. He sprinted through the corridors, a blur of black and gold as he navigated the ship's labyrinthine layout. The crew, well-versed in their captain's intensity, scrambled out of his path with practiced precision. The more inexperienced hands, caught off-guard, barely managed to dive out of the way in time.

Arriving at the bridge, he was greeted by the urgent hum of activity. The chief sonar technician, eyes wide and hands shaking slightly, handed over a report. The message was clear: three pistol shrimp were closing in fast. The report detailed their approach with unnerving accuracy—pulsing waves of sonar readings that indicated their rapid advance, accompanied by the telltale, rhythmic thrum of their tiny pedaling feet and the ominous crackle of their supersonic snapping claws.

The pistol shrimp, once a modest sea creature no bigger than a human hand, had undergone a nightmarish transformation on Europa. Their size had ballooned to that of a full-grown man, and their natural ability to produce a supersonic underwater punch remained intact, now magnified to a formidable weapon. These colossal crustaceans were more than a mere nuisance; they were a significant threat, capable of wreaking havoc on any unsuspecting vessel.

“Report!” the captain barked, his voice slicing through the chaos on the bridge. The crew snapped to attention, their faces illuminated by the harsh glow of the console screens as they monitored the encroaching threat.

The chief sonar technician, taking a deep breath, began relaying the critical details. The approaching shrimp were moving with alarming speed and precision, their advanced sonar signatures indicating they were honing in on the submarine’s location. The bridge crew’s fingers flew across their consoles, adjusting readings and recalibrating their instruments to account for the approaching menace.

“Captain, their speed and trajectory suggest they’re on a direct path to intercept us. We need to prepare for evasive maneuvers and ready the defensive systems,” the technician reported, trying to keep his voice steady despite the gravity of the situation.

The captain, eyes narrowing, assessed the information with a practiced gaze. “Get the defensive systems online. I want a full readiness report on the sonar platforms and weaponry. If these shrimp want a fight, let’s make sure they get more than they bargained for.”

He turned to the crew, his tone firm but tinged with a determined edge. “Prepare for evasive action. We’ll need to outmaneuver these pests if we’re going to get through this without a scratch. Everyone, stay sharp.”

As the crew sprang into action, the captain took a moment to steady himself, a brief respite before the chaos erupted. His mind raced through possible strategies, weighing the risks and benefits of each maneuver. The bridge hummed with activity, the crew working in seamless coordination to fend off the approaching threat.

The next few minutes would test their resolve and readiness, but the captain was confident in his crew’s ability to handle the situation. After all, facing down a trio of oversized pistol shrimp was just another day in the life of a seafarer.

On the bridge, the captain’s gaze was fixed on the night watch gunnery officer, who was busily plotting trajectories and preparing ammunition loads with the kind of meticulous attention to detail that suggested he was handling a complex chess game rather than gearing up to repel oversized shrimp. The officer worked with practiced precision, his fingers moving over the control panels and loading the appropriate rounds into the gun systems.

The captain, with a steadying breath, turned to the helmsman. “Hold for full reverse,” he commanded. The helmsman, a picture of focused concentration, nodded and began preparing the ship for a rapid reverse maneuver. The bridge crew’s energy shifted, a heightened sense of anticipation palpable as they awaited the captain’s next orders.

The captain then directed his attention back to the gunnery crew. “Prepare to leverage and aim as we come into firing range. Unleash your full barrage, and remember, I want the ship to go into full reverse to bring us to a dead stop once we’ve engaged. We’re not moving an inch until those targets are confirmed neutralized.”

The gunnery officer acknowledged the command, his face set with determination as he relayed the instructions to his team. The crew swiftly made the necessary adjustments, aligning the ship's external guns and calibrating the systems for the impending battle. With everything set, the gunnery officer gave a thumbs-up to signal their readiness to fire.

The captain then turned to the helm officer, giving a curt nod. "We're counting on you to execute the reverse maneuver precisely. We need to stay in position for our full offensive."

Next, the captain focused on the sonar officer, who was already deeply engrossed in monitoring the approach of the pistol shrimp. "Start reading out ranges," the captain instructed. "We need to know exactly when those critters are within our firing range."

The sonar officer, eyes flickering between the screens and the captain, began to call out the distances with a steady, clear voice. The numbers came in measured bursts, each range update adding to the tension in the room as the crew prepared for the imminent confrontation.

The captain, now fully immersed in the tactical dance of the moment, watched as the various departments of the bridge worked in harmony. The rhythmic clatter of equipment and the hum of machinery blended with the captain's steady commands and the gunnery officer's focused preparations. The stage was set for what promised to be a dramatic clash with the oversized pistol shrimp.

The moment of battle was a chaotic symphony of mechanical and auditory assault. As the range readings hit the critical mark, the captain's voice cut through the tense air with a decisive command: "Fire!"

In an instant, the scene erupted into a flurry of action. The distant roar of the ship's guns, initially muted, crescendoed into a deafening thrumming that reverberated through the entire vessel. The rhythmic pounding of artillery unleashed a cascade of kinetic energy, each shot a visible jolt that shook the ship's very bones.

The ship's external guns, primed and ready, unleashed a relentless barrage toward the encroaching pistol shrimp. The recoil from each gunshot sent a reverberating shockwave through the ship's hull, causing the metal to groan in protest. At the same time, the emergency pumps, long dormant, sprang to life with a high-pitched squeal, their mechanical screams echoing through the ship's corridors as they struggled to manage the sudden surge of activity.

The ship, still in the throes of a fierce reverse maneuver, groaned and shuddered as it was dragged to an abrupt halt. The hydraulic systems whined under the strain, the ship's trajectory altering with a jarring jerk that made the floor seem to heave beneath the crew's feet.

The crew, caught in this intense maelstrom, kept their eyes glued to the ammo counters, their nervous glances revealing the palpable tension as each round was fired. The ship's weapons lights cut through the murky water, casting ghostly, flickering beams that barely penetrated the darkness. In these fleeting moments of illumination, the forms of the pistol shrimp became visible, their monstrous figures illuminated in eerie, fleeting flashes.

One of the shrimp, braving the storm of fire, inched dangerously close before the guns' relentless onslaught proved too much. In a final, explosive climax, the last shrimp was obliterated, torn to shreds by the sheer force of the continuous barrage. The water around it churned and boiled, leaving only fragments of the once-threatening predator in its wake.

The tension on the bridge was palpable as the ship's weapons ceased their fire, the crew exhaling collectively as the immediate threat was neutralized. The ship's alarms and the cacophony of battle gradually subsided, leaving behind an echoing silence marked only by the steady hum of the engines and the occasional, relieved murmur of the crew.

With the last echoes of gunfire fading into the cold, dark waters, the gunnery crew monitored their systems closely, eyes darting between readouts and the external sensors. The tension on the bridge was thick, a palpable anticipation hanging in the air.

A junior gunnery officer, trying to lighten the mood after the intense confrontation, broke the silence with a hoarse shout over the comms: "Chunky salsa confirmed, Captain!"

The phrase was a relic from the captain's earlier days, a humorous holdover from battles against Europa's many strange and formidable creatures. The term had originated from a gunnery officer who, in the heat of battle, had been instructed to "fire until they're chunky salsa," a colorful way of saying to keep firing until the enemies were nothing but mangled remains. The joke had stuck, becoming a sort of dark humor tradition among the crew.

The captain, despite the gravity of the situation, allowed himself a wry smile at the familiar term. It was a small, comforting signal that the immediate threat was effectively neutralized. The external cameras, now revealing the debris scattered around the ship, confirmed the junior officer's declaration. The once-menacing pistol shrimp were now nothing more than a grotesque mosaic of shattered exoskeletons and pulverized limbs, strewn about like a macabre confetti.

The sight of the enemy reduced to pieces gave a grim satisfaction, a tangible assurance that the ship was secure, at least for the moment. The crew, reassured by the gunnery officer's confirmation, began to relax, their earlier tension slowly dissolving into the relief of survival.

As the echo of the final gunfire faded into the depths, the ship's internal chaos took over. Damage reports began flooding in, a testament to the unexpected but all-too-familiar aftermath of a high-stakes battle. The combat had roused the ship's engineers and mechanics from their rest, their groggy forms quickly becoming a whirlwind of activity as they set about addressing the various issues caused by the sudden and jarring combat maneuvers.

The first reports came in with the unmistakable clang of metal and the hum of machinery in distress. A pump seal had been blown out, its precious hydraulic fluid now a slick and shiny pool on the floor. A set of ventilation fans had been knocked loose, their once-secure mounts now swinging precariously, creating a rhythmic thumping noise that grated on the nerves of anyone nearby. A junction box, now hanging from its wires like a wayward Christmas ornament, sparked intermittently, adding a small but disconcerting visual and auditory disturbance to the ongoing repairs.

In the midst of this clamor, the chief engineer, who had been rudely awakened from a deep slumber, approached the captain with a look of weary frustration. His disheveled appearance and bleary eyes were a stark contrast to the usual crisply professional demeanor of someone in his position.

“Captain,” he said, his voice heavy with the combined weight of exhaustion and irritation, “we need to talk about that abrupt stop. The remaining coil durability isn’t built to handle that kind of jarring force. The structural frame is also feeling the strain. We’ve got some minor issues cropping up—nothing catastrophic, but it’s enough to worry about. The ship wasn’t exactly designed for such a sudden halt in the middle of a skirmish.”

The captain, who had been piecing together the details of the damage reports, looked up from his console with a thoughtful expression. He nodded, recognizing the gravity of the chief engineer’s concerns. “Understood. I’ll make a note to take it easier on the sudden maneuvers from now on. I appreciate the quick response, though. Let’s make sure these issues are addressed before they become bigger problems.”

The chief engineer gave a curt nod before turning to oversee the immediate repairs. His team, now operating with a mix of fatigue and determination, set to work fixing the loose junction boxes, resealing pumps, and securing the fans. The ship, once again, began to settle into a semblance of normalcy, with the hum of machinery and the clatter of tools serving as a reminder of the constant vigilance required to keep the vessel in working order.

Despite the disarray, the crew’s quick response ensured that the immediate issues were contained, and the ship would continue its journey with a slightly bruised but still formidable presence.

As the night wore on, the captain relinquished control of the bridge to the night watch, his shift giving way to the graveyard crew. He was eager to catch whatever sleep he could before his own midday and afternoon responsibilities began. The submarine settled into its familiar rhythm, with the routine of life aboard proceeding with the usual mix of minor issues and predictable hiccups.

The humming machinery and the occasional murmur of the crew became the backdrop to his much-needed rest. The calm and almost comforting ambiance of the submarine, despite the occasional burst of activity, created a stark contrast to the intense moments of battle he had just experienced.

The rest of his night was surprisingly uneventful, his dreams mercifully absent as he drifted into a deep, uninterrupted sleep. When morning came, it brought with it the soft, comforting sound of rain—like a gentle patter on a hot tin roof—an auditory treat that signaled the beginning of a new day. The captain’s favorite alarm, a soothing and gradual wake-up call, played softly, coaxing him from the world of dreams into the light of wakefulness.

He welcomed the gentle awakening, preferring it to the jarring blare of a standard alarm. As he roused himself from the cocoon of slumber, the familiarity and tranquility of his morning routine

offered a peaceful transition into the day's responsibilities. The submarine, now operating smoothly and with renewed steadiness, seemed to echo his own shift back into a more predictable and manageable rhythm.

After a long day of managing the crew and overseeing transit and repairs, the captain found himself approached by the chef, who, with the practiced air of someone who's seen it all, presented a request. The chef and a few mechanics had spotted a promising cluster of sea life that looked like it could be suitable for human consumption. They wanted to take a brief detour to harvest some fresh seafood.

The captain mulled it over, weighing the benefits of a bit of fresh variety against the time lost. Eventually, he gave the nod, allowing the chef and a select few mechanics to suit up in their diving gear for an undersea expedition. It didn't take long for them to return with an impressive haul of plump, unsuspecting sea life. These creatures, blissfully unaware of the human presence, were quickly prepped and cleaned with only minor barnacles needing to be removed.

That evening, the crew and the captain enjoyed a well-deserved feast of fresh seafood. While fresh, edible sea life wasn't too rare, it could get monotonous eating the same hydroponically grown or synthesized rations day in and day out. So, having a meal that was not only fresh but also varied was a welcome change.

The captain was not exactly thrilled to hear from Dario that some of the electrical engineers had decided to adopt a philosophy that bore an uncanny resemblance to separatist rhetoric. It seemed that while they were down there in the depths of Europa, their minds decided to wander to some very terrestrial, and distinctly rebellious, ideas.

Dario, with his usual calm efficiency, reported that there were no actual problems yet—just some of the crew waxing poetic about their newfound, if uninvited, ideological enthusiasm. The captain, who was clearly less than amused, gave a look that could curdle milk. This wasn't the first time some crew members had flirted with separatist ideals.

These kinds of philosophical meanderings were a dime a dozen among the crew, especially when it came to the ideals of returning to Earth—be it in terms of governance, food, or organizational structure. The captain knew that if their separatist fervor was strong enough, they'd eventually find some reason to jump ship anyway.

He had learned over the years that trying to quash these tendencies was about as effective as trying to keep a boat from rocking in rough seas. So, he did what he always did: let them run their course. If their ideals started getting in the way of the ship's operation or crew morale, he'd show them the door with as much grace as he could muster. Until then, he just rolled his eyes and carried on, keeping his ship—and his sanity—intact.

As the days of navigation wore on, the crew faced the typical trials and tribulations of submarine life in the harsh environment of Europa. Their route was peppered with the occasional hazard, like wayward sea mines and the eerie remains of other submarines. These derelict hulks, long since stripped of anything remotely valuable, now served as grim reminders of the dangers

lurking beneath the ice. They were picked clean by the relentless life forms of Europa, leaving nothing but skeletal remains and a stark warning to any who might follow in their path.

Navigating through the icy channels became a delicate dance of precision and patience. The crew maneuvered expertly, avoiding the remnants of past misadventures and guiding the submarine through narrow passages with the expertise that came from years of experience. The icy labyrinths were both beautiful and treacherous, with glistening walls of ice reflecting eerie light from the submarine's searchlights.

Despite the challenges, the crew's resolve remained steadfast. They pushed on, their sights firmly set on their destination. The captain, ever vigilant, monitored every sonar ping and navigation readout with a practiced eye, ensuring their path remained clear and their progress steady.

As they approached their destination, the atmosphere on board was a mix of relief and anticipation. The icy channels, while treacherous, had been navigated with skill and determination, and the crew was ready to face whatever awaited them next. The journey had tested their mettle, but their expertise and camaraderie had seen them through the perilous depths of Europa's icy seas.

As the ship edged closer to its destination, the captain couldn't help but reflect on the voyage with a sense of satisfaction. Despite the usual challenges of navigating the icy labyrinth of Europa and dodging the occasional wayward sea mine or the skeletal remains of other submarines—gruesome reminders of past failures—the journey had been relatively smooth. There had been no catastrophic incidents, no screaming plunges to the ocean floor, and certainly no major battles with aggressive sea life.

Sure, they'd encountered some particularly frisky marine creatures that required a few well-aimed volleys to dispatch, but that was all in a day's work. The captain had managed to keep ammunition costs in check while maintaining high morale among the crew. Nothing rattles a crew like an unexpected descent into the abyss, and avoiding such scenarios had kept everyone in good spirits. The ship had performed admirably, and the crew was in fine form, ready to handle whatever came their way.

As they approached the mining station, the captain could see the bustle of activity in the settlement. Small craft darted about, and the occasional signal from the colony's various systems flickered on the ship's sensors. It was the usual cacophony of a busy mining hub—nothing out of the ordinary, just the rhythm of industrial life on Europa.

With a practiced hand, the captain hailed the dock commander and was swiftly patched through to the harbor master. Arrangements were made for a birthing dock not far from their destination, right next to one of the mining punctures that had requested the supplies they were delivering. It was a straightforward docking, just another day in the life of a seasoned space captain.

The captain leaned back, satisfied with the smooth execution of their mission. The mundane routine of preparing for offloading, coupled with the promise of a quiet end to the voyage, was a

welcome break from the more dramatic episodes that punctuated their timeChapter 2 of caves and crawlers

Chapter 2: Of Caves & Crawlers

As the docking clamps snapped into place with a familiar thud, the captain felt a wave of routine wash over him. This was nothing new—the practiced ease of locking down to a port, the practiced dance of docking logistics, the steady cadence of the crew going through the motions they'd done a thousand times before. It should have been a moment of relief, but something tugged at the back of his mind. There was an itch, a faint whisper of caution that he couldn't quite shake. The communications with the dock commander and then the harbor master had felt... off. Not wrong enough to sound alarms, but enough to set his instincts on edge. What was it? He couldn't put his finger on it, but the whisper wouldn't stop.

But the captain was a man of practicality, and there was no time to dwell on gut feelings when there were tasks to be handled. He brushed aside the lingering sense of unease and turned his attention to the bridge crew, gearing up for the usual post-docking operations. With a practiced authority, he began doling out orders.

"Alright," he said, locking eyes with his chief of security, "first things first—get a listing of all the rules and regulations for this station. You know the drill. I don't want anyone getting thrown in the brig because they didn't know about some obscure mining colony rule about helmet decals or something."

The chief of security nodded, already mentally drafting the email to the station's regulatory office. The captain then turned to his chief engineer, who was leaning against a console, looking half-interested in the conversation.

"And once Security's got the rules, you can start sending your team out to scrounge up any parts we need. You know how these places are. If we're lucky, we might find some halfway decent equipment in the salvage piles. If we're unlucky, well... at least we'll get a good story out of it."

The chief engineer gave a tired grin. The art of scavenging in outposts like this was practically an Olympic sport, and his team was seasoned at finding diamonds in the rough—or at least, parts that wouldn't fail immediately after installation.

Next, the captain's gaze shifted to his chief of operations, who was already jotting down notes on a datapad. "And once Engineering's done with their treasure hunt, give the chefs the green light to start looking for food. Not that I expect much. This is a mining outpost, after all. But hey, maybe they'll surprise us with something that doesn't taste like it was grown in a vat. If not, we'll survive on the usual slop."

The chief of operations nodded with a knowing smirk. These mining colonies weren't exactly known for their culinary delights, but sometimes you got lucky, and at the very least, it would break the monotony of the usual shipboard fare.

Finally, the captain turned to his comms officer. "You," he said, pointing, "I want you to spend the next hour trolling through the station indexes and contact lists. Find me that Kasaran contact vendor for our contract drop-off. They're supposed to be looking for us, so if you can't find them, they should find us. But let's not leave it to chance, alright?"

The comms officer gave a quick nod and immediately started pulling up station directories. The captain leaned back in his chair for a moment, surveying the bridge. The crew was already moving into action, each person executing their part of the plan like a well-oiled machine. It was almost enough to ease that nagging feeling in the back of his mind. Almost.

"Alright," he muttered to himself, "let's see how smoothly this little milk run actually goes."

The captain stepped back from the bustle of his crew, their conversations and plans swirling around the bridge as they started organizing for their various tasks. With a small sigh of relief, he turned toward his private cabin, eager for a brief respite from the chaotic energy of the ship. Inside his sanctuary, the first thing he did was indulge in his guilty pleasure—a precious stash of synthetic coffee. Sure, it wasn't the real thing, but it was close enough to satisfy his craving, especially when he doubled up on the servings. As the familiar, albeit fake, aroma filled the small space, he allowed himself a moment of calm.

Then, with an almost ceremonial air, he reached into a small locker and pulled out an object few people knew he even possessed: a little orange book. Not just any book, mind you, but an old relic from the early days of Europa settlement. Back then, this standards and practices manual had been standard issue for every captain, long before his time on this icy moon. Nowadays, it was practically an antique—definitely out of print and hard to come by. He could imagine a few younger captains raising their eyebrows at the sight of it, probably thinking it was some kind of outdated joke. But no, this little orange book held valuable nuggets of information that could save your hide in the right situation.

And right now, he had just the situation in mind.

You see, one of the little gems tucked away in this forgotten manual was a tidbit that every smart captain on Europa should treasure: a little-known fact about docking procedures. Back in the early days of submarine and dockyard design, someone had the bright idea that any submarine docking at a station would be connected not just to basic life support and refueling lines but also to a built-in hard line for power and communications. The beauty of this setup? It meant that a sub commander could tap directly into the station's infrastructure—specifically, the station administrator's office—without anyone knowing. A secret, direct line, if you will.

With a smirk that only comes from knowing a trick others have forgotten, the captain crossed the room and pulled a hard-shelled comm unit from the wall. He punched in the necessary series of numbers, initiating a landline connection straight to the station administrator's office. No going

through public channels, no waiting on hold—just a direct, untraceable line that let him bypass all the usual station bureaucracy. This, my friends, was the kind of thing you couldn't buy with money.

As he waited for the line to connect, the captain couldn't help but marvel at the foresight of those early settlers. Sure, they'd probably been dealing with the chaos of establishing new colonies on a distant moon, trying to survive in an alien ocean with unknown dangers lurking around every corner, but hey, they'd had the good sense to build in a direct comm line for captains. Priorities, right?

The line he was using was an old relic, a remnant from the early days of colonial establishment on Europa—a time when everything was still shiny and new, and the first settlers were just figuring out how to survive in the icy depths of a moon's ocean. Back then, those station administrators had been given a dedicated hardline communication to what was essentially the only military presence available on Europa: the Navy and its fleet of submarines. This connection had been a lifeline for those early administrators, giving them direct access to the only real source of defense and transportation on the moon.

Fast forward to the present, and this once-crucial system was little more than an afterthought—a dusty artifact of a bygone era. On most stations, the hardlines were so poorly maintained that getting a clear signal was a miracle. Instead, you'd usually be treated to a symphony of crackles, pops, and static that made it sound like you were communicating through a long-forgotten radio from the 1940s. You'd think that with all the advancements in technology, they'd have upgraded the system by now, but no. Europa had a way of holding on to its past, whether you liked it or not.

Yet despite the outdated tech and questionable maintenance, most station commanders or administrators still made sure these lines were at least operational. After all, having a direct link to any wayward sub commander who docked at their station wasn't something to scoff at. There were plenty of scenarios where a station administrator would want a quiet, secure channel to talk with the only transportation on or off their station—much less the only military force that might be within hundreds of miles.

The fact that these lines often led directly to submarine commanders who may or may not answer to their command only added to the intrigue. Station administrators had a delicate dance to perform, balancing their authority with the needs and whims of sub commanders who nominally answered to the Coalition. Those who managed Coalition-aligned stations generally did a better job at keeping these priority lines in good working order. After all, when you're responsible for a facility surrounded by hostile waters, it pays to stay on good terms with the people who could torpedo their way out of trouble—or into it.

So, while the line might've been a creaky old anachronism, the captain couldn't help but appreciate its enduring utility. Sure, it wasn't as glamorous as the newer communication systems, but when you wanted to get something done without any bureaucratic meddling, this old line was still the way to go.

When the captain finally heard a ringing tone through the old hardline, he wasn't surprised that it was, for once, only vaguely crackling. The fact that it rang at all without immediately cutting off was practically a miracle. A few minutes passed—because of course, nothing in the colonies could be quick—before the line finally clicked over to a haggard voice on the other end.

"Hello? To whom might I have the honor?" The voice was strained, not so much irritated as it was just... tired. The kind of tired that only comes from years of dealing with stubborn machinery and equally stubborn people.

Captain Hadler cleared his throat and launched into the usual honorifics, rattling off his name, title, submarine, and the purpose of his visit. "Captain Hadler of the *Resolute*, Suther-class submarine, delivering critical supplies under Kasaran contract. We're here to help build your next big thing, Commander." He layered in a bit of charm, though with these old-timers, it was always a gamble whether they'd appreciate it or not. Still, he went through the routine niceties, trying to be as formal as possible while still hinting that he was here to make both of their lives easier.

There was a pause on the other end of the line before the voice returned, sounding a little more collected, if still rough around the edges. "Captain Hadler, well met. This is Commander Sloan, administrator of this fine establishment. I must admit, it's been quite a while since I've had the pleasure of an introduction via hardline. Most captains prefer to introduce themselves in person or through open comms, but... this is a nice touch." There was a hint of amusement in the commander's voice, like he was remembering some ancient protocol lesson from a long time ago.

Hadler smiled to himself. He'd guessed as much—most modern captains barely knew the hardline existed, let alone how to use it. This was the kind of thing only the old guard or sticklers for the rules bothered with anymore. "Well, Commander," Hadler replied smoothly, "I've always found that the old ways can still come in handy. You never know when a bit of tradition might open a door or two."

Sloan chuckled, the sound crackling slightly through the line. "Touché, Captain. Though I'm guessing you didn't call just to reminisce about the good old days. What can I do for you?"

Ah, now for the real business. Hadler leaned back in his chair, keeping his tone casual but with a hint of opportunity. "Well, Commander, since you've got me on the line and all, I was wondering if there's anything you might need. We're here for the Kasaran delivery, of course, but my crew and I are flexible. If you've got any other jobs that don't exactly fall under the Coalition's purview, we're more than capable of handling them."

There was a long pause, and Hadler could almost hear the gears turning in Sloan's head. Station commanders were always juggling a dozen problems, but getting one to admit they needed help was another story. Finally, Sloan responded, his voice measured. "At the moment,

there's nothing I urgently need from a submarine crew, Captain. But... you never know. Something might come up in the near future. I'll keep you in mind."

Hadler took that as a win. He'd planted the seed, and in a place like this, it didn't take long for problems to crop up. "Appreciate it, Commander. We'll be here for a while offloading the Kasaran shipment and some extra cargo. If you think of anything in the meantime, don't hesitate to let me know. We're more than happy to help."

"Understood, Captain. Enjoy your stay, and good luck with the offloading. Sloan out." The line clicked off with a satisfying finality, and Hadler couldn't help but smirk to himself. Nothing immediate, but at least he'd established the connection. With the proper introduction and a subtle reminder of his capabilities, he'd likely hear from Sloan again before they left.

Stretching his arms above his head, the captain figured he'd earned himself a bit of downtime. As tempting as it was to dive straight into a new project, the mountain of progress reports from the ship's doctor caught his eye. He groaned internally—crew health evaluations were always a mixed bag. The last thing he wanted to deal with were erratic readings that could indicate anything from stress to something more serious.

He thumbed through the reports, frowning at the irregularities. The doctor's notes were... concerning, to say the least. Some of the readings looked off enough that they warranted a face-to-face conversation.

"Great," Hadler muttered to himself. "Just what I needed—another mystery on top of everything else." Tomorrow morning, a chat with the doctor was definitely in order. For now, he leaned back in his chair, trying to focus on anything other than the endless stream of responsibilities waiting for him on the other side of sleep.

He turned in for the night to a relatively restless sleep. Only the smooth whispers almost glass like oblivion stole him for the night dreams of a great dark void filled his mind just as easily they vanished into the mornings mixture of alarms, The soft thrumming of rain on a hot tin roof.

He awoken roused himself for the day enjoying his morning repast he made his way to the galley to assist the kitchen crew preparing for the day's meeting for some reason the captain enjoyed this ritual, The helping the kitchen orderlies organize the galley into a proper conference room for him and his department heads A soothing part of the schedule that he didn't necessarily need to complete but one that felt good to take part in,a reach back to his roots.

Captain Hadler stood near the doorway, arms crossed, quietly watching as his department heads filed into the galley. There was always a certain energy in the air before these meetings—each head of department bringing their own personality into the mix.

Dario, the head of security, was the first to arrive. He strolled in with a confident air, his uniform immaculate as usual. He gave the captain a curt nod before claiming a seat near the front.

"Morning, Captain. Any separatist trouble I should be aware of, or is this just another friendly check-in?" he asked with a half-smile, his tone both professional and teasing.

"Nothing yet, Dario," the captain replied dryly. "But keep your eyes peeled. You never know when someone's going to start preaching the virtues of Earth governments again."

Next came Chief Engineer Eddie, a grizzled veteran who had been with Captain Hadler since the early shuttle days. Eddie walked in with the steady pace of someone who had seen it all, carrying a datapad tucked under his arm. "Captain," he said with a nod before eyeing the coffee pot. "If I'm going to sit through this, I'll need a cup of that sludge you call coffee."

The captain grinned. "Help yourself, Eddie. It's the best synthetic brew we've got."

Eddie chuckled as he poured himself a cup, taking a seat next to Dario. "What's the crisis this time? Another day, another fire to put out?"

The captain was about to respond when Henry, the Chief of Operations, breezed in, looking slightly frazzled but trying to play it cool. "Sorry, sorry—running late," he said, quickly sliding into a chair. "You'd think running this boat was a one-man show the way they keep coming to me with every little issue."

Dario shot him a look. "You'd better not be slacking, Henry. We've got enough on our plates without the Ops department falling behind."

"Slacking? Me? Never!" Henry quipped, flashing a grin. "Just keeping the wheels turning."

As they bantered, Kevin, the Chief Electrical Engineer, sauntered in, wearing his usual smirk. "Heard my name being thrown around in here. What's the verdict? Am I a hero or a villain today?" he asked, plopping down into a chair and putting his feet up on the table.

Hadler eyed Kevin with a mix of amusement and exasperation. "Depends. Did you manage to avoid frying any systems this time?"

Kevin laughed, leaning back. "No promises, Captain. But hey, no separatists on my watch. That counts for something, right?"

Before Hadler could retort, "Zypher," the Master Gunner, walked in, silent and imposing as ever. He rarely engaged in the banter, preferring to let his reputation as a no-nonsense gunner do the talking. He simply nodded at the captain and took a seat near the back, folding his arms.

Finally, Jenna, the ship's chef, bustled in from the kitchen, wiping her hands on her apron. "Alright, Captain, everything's ready. Got the best synth rations on the menu today, so don't expect any complaints."

"Never do, Jenna," Hadler replied with a grin. "Your cooking is the only thing keeping us sane."

As the department heads settled in, Hadler took a moment to observe them all. These were his people, the backbone of his operation, each bringing their own quirks and expertise to the table. They were a dysfunctional family at times, but they were his dysfunctional family. And they were the best crew he could ask for.

As the meeting settled into place, Captain Hadler cleared his throat, signaling the start of the discussions. "Alright, everyone. Let's dive in. I've been in touch with the Kasaran dockyards. It turns out our early delivery is quite the windfall. The contract manager was green, but after some back-and-forth, we confirmed that our shipment will be rewarded handsomely—more than enough to cover the ammo we burned through. We've set up the offload schedule, but there's some nuance to manage."

He turned to Eddie, the Chief Engineer. "Eddie, you'll need to coordinate with the dockyard workers. They should be arriving shortly. Ensure they follow the proper unloading procedures and confirm that all equipment gets stored properly. We've got some sensitive gear in this shipment, so let's not have any mishaps."

Eddie nodded, taking notes. "Got it. I'll get on that right away. Anything else?"

The captain hesitated, then shifted to a more pressing matter. "Before we move on, we need to address a potential issue that's been brewing. It seems we might have an orphan radioactive source somewhere on the submarine. This could be why some of our crew members have been showing erratic health readings."

The room fell silent as the gravity of the situation settled in. Chrider, the ship's Head Doctor, spoke up first. "Captain, if we have radiation leaks, it could be affecting crew health in ways we haven't fully identified. We need to address this promptly."

Dario, the Head of Security, leaned forward. "I can get the security team on this. We've got the personnel, and we can run a full sweep with the Geiger counters. But it's going to take time, and we need to consider how it might impact our unloading schedule."

Kevin, the Chief Electrical Engineer, chimed in. "Why not just send a couple of engineers with Geiger counters? We can quickly scan the main areas and see if anything pops up. A full kit sweep is overkill if we don't know where the problem is."

Jenna, standing by the food counter, raised an eyebrow. "And if we miss it? We could end up with long-term health issues for the crew. A quick sweep might not be enough."

Henry, Chief of Operations, nodded in agreement. "We should weigh the options carefully. A full sweep might delay the offloading process, but if it prevents further radiation exposure, it's worth the time."

The captain took a deep breath, assessing the situation. "Alright, here's the plan. I want a preliminary scan done with Geiger counters by a small team of engineers. They should focus on areas where radiation might most likely accumulate—places with shielding, equipment, or any

potential leaks. Security can assist in ensuring that the operation doesn't disrupt our unloading schedule. We'll keep the medical team on standby in case we need more detailed investigations or immediate health interventions."

Dario nodded. "Understood. I'll coordinate with the engineers and make sure they have what they need. We'll work around the offload schedule to minimize disruption."

Chride added, "I'll monitor the crew's health closely and be ready to act if needed. If we find any crew members with abnormal readings, we'll address their exposure immediately."

With that, Hadler looked around at his department heads, a sense of resolve settling over him. "Let's get to it, then. We've got a busy day ahead. Eddie, you handle the unloading. Dario, Kevin, and the engineers, get started on that sweep. Chride, stay vigilant."

As the department heads began to disperse, Hadler took a moment to reflect. It was one of those days where the operational demands and the unexpected challenges collided, but with his capable team by his side, he felt confident they'd navigate through it. They had tackled countless issues before, and this would be no different.

The meeting had been efficient, if not exactly smooth. They had talked through the unloading schedule for the Kasaran contracts first, Eddie leading the charge with a detailed breakdown of how they'd offload both the standard cargo and the extra they'd picked up before leaving port. Which storage spaces would get priority which cargo's would be dealt with first, Seven grueling shifts—full crew rotations—to get it all through the cramped dock ports and narrow gangways. The industrial moon pools were occupied, as usual, with bulk cargo-haulers cycling ore in and out, feeding Europa's insatiable industry. The constant churn of machinery was almost hypnotic, a never-ending dance that spoke to the hunger of this moon's economy, running at full tilt to keep the lights on in the scattered domes and outposts clinging to life beneath the ice. The long green dove advantage of using the moon pools the southern class ships didn't take into account the sheer size of the bulk loaders practically requiring them, Meaning that if they had a bulk later lined up to use it or waiting for access, they got priority use.

Captain hadler hadn't seen them running at this breakneck speed in his entire career, They were constantly unloading full submarines of ore's quick as they could dump loads.

The captain could almost hear the distant grind of heavy loaders and docking clamps as they discussed the schedule. He imagined the scene outside: towering ore carriers, their massive hulls dipping into the moon pools, loading raw materials with all the grace of lumbering giants. His own submarine felt like an ant by comparison, scurrying around in the shadows of these behemoths, carrying its relatively small but vital payload of scientific equipment and food supplies.

Eddie had assured him that everything was in hand, but the captain could see the strain in his friend's face. They were pushing the crew hard. It would be seven shifts of non-stop work, with barely any rest between them. The docks were crowded, and the gangways were tight, meaning every crate had to be carefully maneuvered through narrow passageways, one at a time, Either

on cargo dollies or literally carried by hand , It was a grueling process, and the captain knew it would wear on the crew's nerves. But there was no other choice. The moon pools were off-limits to them, reserved for the larger ships whose payloads outweighed theirs by orders of magnitude.

Dario and Kevin had still argued briefly about who should handle the sweeps. Dario's security team was more than capable of managing the Geiger counters, but Kevin insisted that the engineers were better equipped to identify the problem areas Not to mention battery certified in radiation protocol. The captain had watched them bicker, half-amused and half-exasperated. It was a familiar routine—security wanting to control the situation, engineering insisting they knew the ship better. In the end, they'd compromised: a joint sweep, with both teams working together to cover the most ground in the shortest amount of time.

The captain had let them hash it out, his mind drifting to the bigger picture. This radiation issue wasn't just a technical problem. It was a symptom of something deeper, something that had been festering on Europa for a long time now. The station, the docks, the moon itself—it all felt stretched thin, like a worn-out machine on the verge of breaking down. The people he'd talked to over the past few days were either painfully young or disturbingly old. There was no middle ground, no solid core of seasoned professionals to hold everything together. Europa was running out of time, running out of people who knew how to keep things running smoothly. The gaps were showing, and they were widening with every passing day.

After the meeting, the captain had wandered down to the cargo bay, watching as the crew worked. Crates were being hoisted onto dolly carts, wheeled through narrow passages with careful precision. The air was thick with sweat and concentration. He had wanted to help, to do something with his hands, but he knew better. His place was up top, coordinating, keeping the bigger picture in mind. But it didn't stop him from feeling restless, from wanting to be down there in the thick of it with his crew, instead of sitting on the sidelines.

As the hours stretched on, the weight of responsibility pressed down harder. The radiation sweep was underway, the cargo was being offloaded, and the crew was holding up—barely. But the captain couldn't shake the feeling that they were all teetering on the edge of something far worse than they realized. The moon was hungry, always hungry, and it demanded more from them with every passing day. Seven shifts, 2 and a half days of backbreaking work, and for what? To feed a machine that never stopped, that never gave back, only took and took and took.

The captain sighed, rubbing his temples as he stared out at the dimly lit corridors of his submarine. There was no time for rest, not yet. The work wasn't done, and the future felt uncertain, more so than it had in years. But for now, all he could do was keep moving forward, one step at a time, hoping that they could hold things together just a little bit longer.

Captain Hadler spent most of his time hunched over the comms, staring at the screen with weary eyes as he cycled through the endless calls. The cargo offload was progressing as scheduled, but the prospect of downtime loomed ahead. Without another contract lined up, his

sub would sit idle, burning fuel and draining credits while the crew grew restless. Every day spent without a job was a day closer to insolvency. Europa didn't tolerate stagnation. Neither did he.

Each call was the same. He'd ping the number of a corporate contact or logistics manager and wait for the brief, perfunctory conversation that followed. The voices on the other end were always harried, hurried, too busy to engage beyond the standard protocol. They spoke in clipped tones, offered him boilerplate contracts that had clearly been sent to a dozen other ships before him. Transport this, deliver that—simple jobs with low pay, barely enough to cover operating costs. When he tried to negotiate for something better, they would brush him off with an excuse or, worse, radio silence. They had no time for the likes of him, not when they were already drowning in work themselves.

But he couldn't afford to turn any of it down. He kept notes, tallying the contracts he could accept, the ones that weren't worth the fuel, and the few that might hold promise. Most were the same—low-priority cargo runs, nothing with any real reward. He'd need to take on several just to break even. He was being offered the same rates the bulk cargo carriers were but didn't have the capacity to match their ability to turn a profit. The frustration gnawed at him, and every call left him feeling more drained, more desperate. And those that did demanded time schedules that were frankly unreasonable.

Then came the call that broke the monotony. His comm unit buzzed with an incoming transmission, and when he saw the source, his eyebrows lifted in surprise. It was Sloan, the station administrator. Sloan was a busy man, never one for casual conversation unless there was something important on the line.

The captain answered, leaning back in his chair as the screen flickered to life. Sloan's familiar face appeared, wearing that same half-smile, half-smirk that Hadler had come to associate with trouble.

"Heyo, Captain," Sloan greeted him, his voice casual but with an undercurrent of something more. "I hear the offload's going well?"

Hadler nodded, glancing at the status reports on his terminal. "Yeah, we're about halfway done. Seven shifts for the full unload, Crew's holding up, but they're exhausted. It's been grueling work, especially with the moon pools occupied. We're running everything through the gangways, piece by piece."

Sloan made a noise that was somewhere between sympathy and dismissal. "Europa never makes it easy, does it? But hey, I've got something that might interest you. A little more dangerous than the usual fare, but it pays well. You've been looking for something a bit more... substantial, haven't you?"

Hadler's interest piqued, but he kept his expression neutral. "What's the job?"

Sloan leaned in closer to the screen, lowering his voice as if the details were too sensitive to speak aloud at normal volume. "It's a contract with the European Society for Safety—the ESS. Technically an arm of the Coalition, but they're pretty independent. There's been a report of Crawlers setting up a lair in a nearby cave system. Nasty little bastards, you know how they are. ESS wants someone to take care of it before they become a real problem."

The captain's mind raced. Crawlers—those agile, predatory creatures that thrived in the dark recesses of Europa's oceans—were no small threat. They were fast, clever, and territorial, and a pack of them in a cave system could spell disaster if left unchecked. Still, the job had potential. Dangerous, yes, but he'd dealt with worse. And if the pay was good...

"Tricky indeed," Hadler muttered, his gaze locking onto Sloan's, searching for any hint of deception. He could feel the weight of unspoken dangers lurking beneath the surface. "So, what's the real catch?"

Sloan chuckled, though the sound carried an uneasy edge as he scratched the back of his neck. "Catch is, they're insisting on an observer from ESS. Andrews Keflars—head of the local ESS unit—wants to ensure everything is done by the book. He's one of those Coalition hardliners. Obsessed with oversight and regulations. Won't interfere if you stick to protocol. But..." Sloan's voice dropped, his eyes darkening with a quiet warning. "Just keep him alive, Captain. The last crew didn't manage that, and you know what's waiting out there if we don't."

The shadow of failure loomed large, and Hadler could feel the ghosts of the doomed ship echo in Sloan's words, like distant screams swallowed by the abyss.

Hadler frowned, considering the complications that an observer could bring to the operation. Extra eyes meant extra scrutiny, and Keflars sounded like the type who'd be watching every move they made. But if the ESS was involved, the payout would be substantial, especially if they managed to clear the cave system efficiently that had given them trouble. And with Sloan backing the deal, he knew it was a solid opportunity.

"Alright," the captain said finally, his voice steady. "What's the timeline?"

Sloan's grin widened. "Keflars wants to head out within the next couple of days. Keflars wants to get this handled quickly, saying now's the best time to strike. I can forward you the details, get you in touch with Keflars, and you can hash out the rest. What do you say, Captain? You up for a little pest control?"

Hadler exhaled slowly, feeling the weight of the decision settle on his shoulders. It wasn't the safe, easy job he'd been hoping for, but it was a job with real pay, real stakes. And right now, that was exactly what they needed.

"Send me the details, Sloan," the captain said, his voice firm. "We'll take the job."

Sloan's grin turned into a full smile. "That's what I like to hear. I'll make sure Keflars knows to expect your call. Good luck, Captain. I'll be keeping an eye on things from here."

The call ended, leaving Hadler staring at the now-blank screen. He took a deep breath, already planning the next steps in his mind. There was no time to waste. The crew needed to rest, the ship needed to be prepped, and he had to make contact with Keflars to ensure everything was in place.

Dangerous or not, this was the kind of job that could keep them afloat, at least for a little while longer.

Captain Hadler didn't waste any time. As soon as the call with Sloan ended, he keyed in the ESS contact number Sloan had provided. The familiar hum of the ELF comms filled the cabin as he waited for the connection to go through. The line buzzed, clicking through various levels of automated messaging, and finally, he was greeted by the voice of a secretary.

"European Society for Safety, how may I direct your call?"

"I need to speak with Andrews Keflars," Hadler said, his tone firm and no-nonsense. "Captain Hadler of the *Resolute*. It's regarding a contract with the ESS."

There was a moment of hesitation on the other end of the line, followed by a short shuffle of papers. The voice returned, polite but with a hint of bureaucratic detachment. "One moment, Captain. I'll see if Mr. Keflars is available."

What followed was an irritatingly familiar round of transfers, hold music, and brief exchanges with underlings who seemed determined to keep him from reaching the man in charge. Each conversation felt like another layer of red tape. But Hadler was nothing if not persistent, and after several minutes of this runaround, the line finally cleared, and the voice on the other end took on a different tone—one of authority.

"Captain Hadler, is it?" The voice was smooth, with the practiced cadence of someone used to being listened to. "This is Andrews Keflars. I understand you're interested in the contract we've put out."

Hadler leaned back in his chair, assessing the man's tone as much as his words. "That's right. Sloan briefed me on the basics. Crawlers setting up shop in a nearby cave system. My sub, the *Resolute*, can handle a job like that, no problem."

There was a pause on the other end, and then Keflars's image flickered onto the comm screen. The man looked exactly as his voice had suggested—elderly but not frail, with a dignified

bearing that came from decades of experience. He was dressed in what looked like a high-ranking ESS uniform, immaculately pressed and adorned with medals that signified more than just ceremonial rank. His eyes, sharp and assessing, locked onto Hadler through the screen.

"Captain," Keflars said, inclining his head slightly in acknowledgment, "we've had good reports about the *Resolute*. I'm told she's well-equipped for missions in Europa's depths. But this isn't just a simple hunting expedition. Crawlers are notoriously aggressive, and this cave system isn't exactly charted. I need to be certain that your vessel and crew can handle what might come."

Hadler nodded, understanding the need for assurance. "The *Resolute* is more than capable. We've got a forward railgun that can handle long-range engagements, a top-mounted assault gun for rear coverage, and coil guns both top and bottom for close-quarters work. Our dive ops compartment is large enough to support extended missions underwater, and we've recently upgraded the hull. While it's not a double-hull design, the reinforcements have made it tough enough to withstand the pressure down there. We've taken her deep, and she holds steady."

Keflars listened intently, his expression remaining composed but clearly evaluating every word. "And your crew?" he asked after a moment. "Are they experienced with combat operations? If these Crawlers are nesting, they won't go down easily. We'll need precision and discipline out there."

Hadler didn't hesitate. "My crew is seasoned. We've faced everything Europa's thrown at us—hostile wildlife, separatists, you name it. They're sharp, efficient, and they know how to keep their cool under pressure. We're not just cargo haulers, Mr. Keflars. We're trained for combat, and we've got the firepower to back it up."

Keflars leaned back slightly, steepling his fingers as he considered Hadler's words. "Good. That's what I wanted to hear. The ESS isn't just looking for someone to kill a few Crawlers—we're looking for a team that can do the job thoroughly and safely. I'll be coming along as an observer, of course. I trust that won't be a problem?"

Hadler allowed himself a slight grin. "Not at all. We'll make sure you get the full tour."

Keflars smiled, though it was more a tight-lipped expression of satisfaction than warmth. "Very well, Captain. I'll forward you the full mission details and schedule. We'll be departing within the next two days. Prepare your vessel and crew accordingly. And Captain..."

Hadler raised an eyebrow. "Yes?"

"I don't tolerate failure," Keflars said, his tone firm. "I expect results. Understood?"

Hadler's gaze didn't waver. "Understood. You'll get them."

The call ended, leaving Hadler alone in the dim light of his cabin. He sat back, his mind already shifting gears, running through the checklist of preparations. The job was risky, no doubt about

that, but it was exactly the kind of work the *Resolute* was built for. And with Keflars along for the ride, there would be no room for mistakes.

Hadler pushed himself up from his chair, the weight of his decisions settling on his shoulders like the press of Europa's frozen seas. The dim light of his cabin flickered slightly as he rubbed the bridge of his nose, thinking ahead to the tasks that lay before him. His mind was a constant churn of logistics, calculations, and risk assessments—this contract with the ESS wasn't just another milk run. It had teeth, and he needed his crew sharp, his ship ready.

As he stood, his gaze flicked to the half-empty cup of coffee on the table. Cold, bitter sludge. Without a second thought, he tipped it back and swallowed. The taste was awful, but he needed the caffeine. There was no room for indulgence here, not now. Everything was about efficiency, survival. He had to keep that edge. The cup hit the table with a dull thud, the sound almost lost in the hum of the ship around him.

He keyed into the ship's internal comm system and fired off a message to the bridge. "Comms, patch me through to all department heads. Flash them a message—schedule change. All hands, first thing in the morning. Full brief. No exceptions."

The line crackled with acknowledgment, and Hadler leaned back in his chair, his mind already moving on to the next step. He needed to talk to Henry, his Chief of Operations. The man was methodical, detail-oriented, and reliable. He'd know how to tighten up the ship's readiness for what was coming. Hadler punched in the direct line to Henry's quarters, listening to the steady tone of the comm ringing in his ear.

After a few rings, the connection clicked on. "Captain?" Henry's voice came through, steady but with a hint of weariness. Long shifts did that, but the man never failed to stay sharp.

"Henry," Hadler said, his tone clipped, straight to the point. "We've got a new job coming down the pipe. ESS contract—Crawler extermination in the caves. Andrews Keflars will be on board as an observer, so I need the ship at one hundred percent. No sloppiness, no loose ends."

"Understood, sir," Henry replied, and Hadler could already hear the wheels turning in his head. "I'll start coordinating with the team. What's the timeline?"

"Two days. Less, if I can get the crew up to speed faster. First thing—armory check. I want fresh eyes on every weapon we've got. Ammo counts, maintenance logs, everything. Get a few of the gunners some range time on the station, quick style. Make sure they're sharp."

Henry was silent for a moment, then spoke. "The armory's in decent shape, but I'll push for a full inventory tonight. The range time might be trickier, given the station's schedule, but I'll get it done. Anything else?"

Hadler leaned forward, resting his elbows on the table. The dim lighting cast harsh shadows across his face. "Yeah. I want you to prep the crew for a deep dive. Those caves aren't charted,

and if there's Crawler nests down there, we need to be ready for anything. Make sure everyone's got their heads in the right place. I don't want any surprises."

"Copy that, Captain. I'll make sure the message gets through."

Hadler nodded, though Henry couldn't see it. "Good. And Henry?"

"Yes, sir?"

"Stay sharp. This isn't like our usual runs. Something about it doesn't sit right with me."

Henry hesitated for a moment, then responded, his voice carrying the weight of experience. "I hear you, Captain. I'll keep the crew on their toes."

Hadler ended the call, staring at the bulkhead in front of him for a long moment. The weight of Europa bore down on them all, the endless cold, the isolation, the crushing depths. It was a world where one mistake could mean death—slow, agonizing, and inevitable. That was the reality of life beneath the ice.

He needed his crew to understand that, to feel it in their bones. Complacency killed out here, as surely as the Crawlers or the separatists. He couldn't afford to let that happen on his watch.

With a grim determination, Hadler stood up and began his rounds. He moved through the ship's narrow corridors, passing the occasional crew member who saluted or nodded respectfully. They could sense the change in his demeanor, the shift in the atmosphere. This wasn't just another supply run. The *Resolute* was gearing up for a fight, and everyone would need to be ready for what lay ahead.

As he approached the armory, he could already hear the clinking of weapons being checked and prepped. The faint smell of gun oil and ozone lingered in the air, a familiar scent in these tight quarters. Henry was there, directing the gunners as they ran through their checks. The man looked up as Hadler entered, nodding once in acknowledgment.

"Everything in order?" Hadler asked, his gaze sweeping over the rows of weapons laid out on the tables.

"Yes, sir," Henry replied. "We've got the inventory sorted. A few minor maintenance issues, but nothing we can't handle. The gunners will get some range time tomorrow morning, station permitting."

Hadler grunted in approval. "Good. Keep at it."

He turned to leave, but Henry's voice stopped him. "Captain... you mentioned something not sitting right. You think this job is more than just Crawlers?"

Hadler paused at the doorway, his hand resting on the cold metal frame. He didn't turn around as he spoke. "Europa doesn't give us easy jobs, Henry. Not anymore. This place... it eats

people alive. The Crawlers are just part of it. Stay sharp, and make sure the crew does too. We get sloppy, we don't come back."

With that, he left the armory, the door hissing shut behind him. He continued his rounds, checking in with various department heads, making sure every system, every station, was ready for what lay ahead. The *Resolute* was a solid ship, but she was only as strong as the people who ran her. And out here, in the frozen hell beneath Europa's surface, strength was the only thing that kept them alive.

Hadler knew that all too well.

Hadler lay on his cot, staring up at the ceiling of his cabin, the faint vibrations of the offloading echoing through the hull. The rhythmic thuds of cargo moving through the gangways were a constant reminder that the job wasn't done. But it wasn't just that. Something gnawed at him—a feeling he couldn't shake. Maybe it was paranoia. Maybe it was the weight of command wearing thin after all these years. Either way, sleep didn't come easy.

The past few weeks had felt... off. Small things. Odd glitches in the systems, strange sonar echoes that didn't quite add up, crew complaints about shadows in the periphery of their vision. It was as if the ship itself was unsettled, creaking and groaning like an old beast stirring from slumber. He told himself it was nothing. They'd been down in these depths too long—everyone was on edge. But still... the feeling lingered.

He closed his eyes, forcing himself to relax, but the sleep that finally took him was restless. It came in fitful waves, the kind of half-sleep that left a man more exhausted than when he lay down. He tossed and turned, the distant rumble of the cargo offload slipping into the recesses of his subconscious.

Then, without warning, the world tilted violently, and the deafening wail of alarms tore through the ship. Hadler shot up in bed, his heart slamming behind his ears. The blare of a depth alert echoed in his ears, but something was wrong—this wasn't just a drill. The sound of gushing water filled the air, a sickening rush of pressure as the hull groaned under some unseen force.

He stumbled out of bed, the floor shifting beneath his already wet feet. His mind struggled to make sense of it all, but then the screams started. Horrible, guttural cries of men in pain, fighting against something unseen, something monstrous. The walls seemed to close in on him as he fumbled for his suit. His fingers were clumsy, trembling, but he forced himself to move faster. His dive suit felt impossibly heavy, like lead weighing him down, but he had to get it on. He had to.

The ship writhed beneath him, twisting and groaning as if some great beast had wrapped its tendrils around the *Resolute* and was slowly crushing it to pieces. The screams grew louder, mingling with the sound of claws scraping against metal—long, jagged nails tearing through the hull, through the men outside his quarters. He could hear them fighting, their voices distorted by fear and pain.

But it wasn't just the sound. No, it was the faces thought the water blurred rent's in the hull of his room. Faces of the dead, men he'd lost over the years, their eyes hollow and accusing. They stared at him through the walls, their mouths twisted into silent screams. He recognized them all—every single one. Men who had died under his command, lives lost in the frozen hell of Europa's depths. They were back now, clawing at the edges of his mind, flayed arms pushing through the holes, dragging him down into the dark with them.

Hadler's breath came in ragged gasps as he clambered into the suit, the world spinning around him. He had to get out, had to fight—something—anything. But before he could react, the nightmare screeched, a deafening wail that seemed to pierce his very soul.

And then, just as suddenly as it had begun, it ended. The ship was quiet. No alarms, no screams, no sound of gushing water. Just silence. Cold, suffocating black silence of his own breathing in a black abyss.

Hadler jolted awake, Breath heaving, drenched in sweat, his heart pounding in his chest. His hands were clenched into fists, his nails digging into his palms. He blinked, disoriented, his mind reeling from the vivid nightmare. It had felt so real—too real. The faces, the screams, the crushing weight of failure. It lingered with him, clinging to the edges of his consciousness like a shadow that wouldn't fade.

He sat up slowly, running a trembling hand through his sweat stained hair. The room was dark, the soft hum of the ship's systems the only sound now. But the fear was still there, gnawing at him. He couldn't shake it, couldn't force it away. He dared not check his reflection in the tiny bathroom mirror, but Adrenaline and a racing heart compelled him to move.

Hadler swung his legs over the edge of the bed, planting his feet on the cold metal floor. He couldn't sleep now. Not after that. Maybe not for the rest of the night. He thought desperately for a moment before he made-up his mind.

Europa didn't wait for anyone. And neither did the darkness that lurked beneath its frozen surface.

He knew it was probably a bad idea but he also knew it was probably one of the only reliable ways to chase away the dark hiding in his own soul.

Captain Hadler dressed quietly in his cabin, slipping into some off-duty civvies—a simple gray sweater, worn leather jacket, and black pants. The nightmare still clung to him, a dark haze that he couldn't quite shake. The tightness in his chest hadn't fully dissipated, and the ship felt too small, too oppressive. He needed air, space, even if it was the stale, recycled atmosphere of the dockside station. A few hours away from the *Resolute* might clear his head. It wasn't like him to take leave, but tonight was different. The salted wounds of memory had been torn open, and staying aboard felt like inviting more of the same.

He pulled on his boots, the familiar weight grounding him as he mentally planned his next steps. The decision came quickly—a dockside bar. Something dimly lit, full of chatter he didn't have to

pay attention to, where the smell of cheap alcohol and cooking oil mingled with the salty tang of Europa's seawater. A place where he could drown out the echoes in his head, if only for a little while.

Hadler sent out a few quick comms messages, informing his department heads and key crew members that he'd be taking a rare moment of leave. He left them a text message not daring a face to face or even voice com's. He made it clear he'd only be gone for a few hours, and if anything critical came up, they knew how to reach him. The messages were direct and to the point—no explanations, just facts. His absence wouldn't disrupt anything. They could handle the ship for a bit without him.

His destination: the "Salted Kipper," a dockside dive he'd heard about from a few of the crew. It was the kind of place that catered to submariners, roughnecks, and station workers—people who'd seen too much and wanted to see nothing at all for a few hours. It was the sort of establishment where anonymity was a given, and the drinks were served strong and fast.

With a final glance around his quarters, Hadler grabbed his com's unit and slipped it into his pocket. He exited his cabin with the practiced silence of a man used to moving unnoticed. As he made his way through the ship's corridors, he didn't encounter any crew—just the low hum of machinery and the occasional distant clatter from the cargo bays. It was almost peaceful, in a way, but peace was a dangerous illusion here. The quiet felt fragile, ready to shatter at the slightest provocation.

Reaching the airlock, he flashed his ID and stepped through. By the time he passed the night Watchmen on the way out of the ship he was calm composed.

The metallic hiss of the doors sealed him off from the ship, and with it, the weight of command seemed to lift just a little. He found himself on the gangway, the lack of sea sway making his steps feel lighter without fighting the slow unending roll of life about ship. The station's dim lighting casting long shadows across the walls.

The path to the "Salted Kipper" wasn't far—just a few turns and an elevator ride down to the lower levels of the dockside. As Hadler walked, the sounds of the station filtered in—muted voices, the clang of metal, the distant hum of machinery. It was a different kind of life than aboard the *Resolute*, one with its own pace and rhythm, but no less grim. Everyone here had their own burdens, their own scars. No one survived Europa's depths without paying the price.

Hadler arrived at the bar, a weathered sign glowing faintly above the entrance. The "Salted Kipper" looked as unremarkable as he'd expected—dark, unassuming, with a few tired souls scattered at the tables inside. The air was thick with the smell of fried food and stale liquor. It was exactly what he needed.

He pushed open the door and stepped inside, feeling the warmth of the place wash over him. The bartender gave him a quick glance, then returned to wiping down glasses, uninterested in anything beyond the next drink order. That suited Hadler just fine.

He found a seat at the far end of the bar, away from the handful of patrons nursing their own drinks and regrets. As he settled onto the stool, he waved the bartender over.

"Whiskey," Hadler said, his voice low. "Neat."

The bartender nodded, pouring a glass without a word, and set it in front of him. Hadler stared at the amber liquid for a moment, the memory of his nightmare still swirling in his mind. He took a slow sip, the burn of the alcohol chasing away some of the cold that had settled in his bones.

For now, the world could wait.

The *Salted Kipper* was beginning to fill up, the murmur of conversation swelling as the night progressed. The warmth of the bar was a welcome reprieve from the cold reality Hadler had left behind on the *Resolute*. He was a few drinks deep by now, the amber liquid dulling the edges of his tension, when the door swung open with a creak.

The place wasn't that bad really it even had what seemed like real wood countertops and table tops, Had to have come from one of the rare Agra-domes where they had grown actual trees

A group of local scarred ruffians, their faces weathered and rough, parted ways with a casual shove as a new figure walked in. It was Andrew Keflars, the man Hadler had spoken to earlier. The bartender, who had been busy tending to the growing crowd, gave a nod of recognition and a subtle gesture towards Hadler's corner, where Andrew's sharp eyes quickly found him.

Andrew moved through the bar with a calm, purposeful stride, and though the place was lively and noisy, there was something solemn about his presence. He and the bartender exchanged a few low words, their conversation lost amidst the clamor of the evening. Andrew's gaze settled on Hadler, and he made his way over, his face etched with the lines of past burdens and unspoken regrets.

"Mind if I join you?" Andrew asked, his voice carrying a gravitas that cut through the din. Hadler gestured to the empty stool beside him, and Andrew took a seat, ordering a drink with a terse nod to the bartender.

As the drinks were brought, Andrew leaned in, his voice low and heavy. "You know, Captain, it's not often I get to sit down with someone who truly understands the weight of command." He took a sip from his glass, the whiskey apparently doing little to mask the sorrow in his eyes. "You might find this hard to believe, but I was once in your shoes—captaining a vessel, dealing with missions that went awry."

Andrew's gaze was distant, as if he was looking through the bar and into another time entirely. "I've seen my share of death, Captain. Too much, if I'm being honest. And it never leaves you, not really. The faces of the dead, the screams of the damned—they follow you."

Hadler listened intently, sensing the depth of Andrew's words. It wasn't just about the mission anymore. There was a weight to Andrew's words that spoke of personal demons and the burden of command.

Andrew continued, his voice dropping to a murmur as he shared more about the mission they were about to undertake. "We had a crew—a batch of young, inexperienced kids. I knew.. some of them. Sent them out on what we thought was a simple job. A chance to cut their teeth, gain some experience. It was supposed to be a minor operation, clearing a small nest of crawlers from a nearby cave."

Andrew's expression hardened, his gaze fixed on the table. "What we didn't know was that the nest was massive. One of the largest we've ever seen. The initial feed from the crew showed a sprawling network of caves. And these weren't just some hatchlings and a few eggs; these were full-grown monsters, with a network that stretched deep into the earth."

He paused, taking another sip from his glass, the alcohol doing little to ease the sorrowful lines of his face. "The problem was, this nest is geologically situated right above the mining colony. We couldn't just bomb it; that would risk burying the entire colony under tons of rubble at worst or triggering collapses in the mines at best. So, we had to clear it out manually. It's going to be long, brutal work."

Andrew looked up, meeting Hadler's eyes. "The crew we sent before—they were young, eager. They thought it would be a simple job, and they paid the ultimate price for my mistake. I've got to make sure that doesn't happen again. This time, I'm going in. I've got skin in the game. No more sending fresh recruits to their deaths."

His voice was resolute, and his eyes, though weary, shone with a fierce determination. "This time, we do it right. By the book. No more inexperienced crews getting eaten alive. We clear the nest, and we do it without unnecessary loss of life."

Hadler nodded, absorbing the gravity of Andrew's words. The mission was far from straightforward, and it was clear that Andrew's involvement was deeply personal. There was no room for error; lives depended on the success of this operation.

As Andrew continued to speak, detailing the complexities of the cave system and the necessity of thorough, careful work, Hadler listened intently. The stakes were high, and the mission was fraught with peril. But if Andrew's resolve was anything to go by, this time they would approach it with the seriousness it deserved.

The conversation carried on into the night, the two men sharing their burdens and their hopes. In the end, the bar was just a backdrop—a place where past and present met, where the weight of command and the necessity of their mission intersected. Although fate had a different idea of how their night would end.

Hadler awoke with a jolt, a pounding headache rousing him from the fog of unconsciousness. Every throb of his pulse sent sharp spikes of agony through his skull, and a dull, persistent pain

on his left side made even the slightest movement a trial. As he blinked through the haze, he became vaguely aware of an unfamiliar noise—a rhythmic snoring that seemed to vibrate through the ship’s steel walls.

He squinted, trying to clear his blurred vision. His once-ordered office had transformed into something almost surreal. A misshapen, lumpy black sofa occupied the center of the room, and sprawled across it was a tattered and bruised form—Andrew Keflars. The sight of Andrew, battered and unmoving, served as a jarring reminder of the previous night’s chaos, fragments of which were now slowly piecing themselves together in Hadler’s throbbing mind.

Hadler glanced down at his own state, noting the torn clothes and the unfamiliar bandage crudely applied to his side. The sharp sting of the injury was a vivid reminder of the night’s events: a bar brawl, a drunken stumble through the docking ring, and a desperate scramble to find help. The hazy memory of securing that lumpy sofa, a grotesque find in the early hours of the morning, was etched into his aching consciousness.

The chime of the door abruptly broke the silence, pulling Hadler from his disoriented reverie. He groaned, his voice rough with exhaustion and pain. “Come in,” he croaked, dreading the arrival of whoever it might be.

The door slid open to reveal Dario, the head of security, his face alight with a grin that suggested he had a particularly entertaining tale to tell. The sight of Hadler’s disheveled state seemed only to heighten Dario’s amusement.

“Captain,” Dario greeted, his voice laced with suppressed laughter.

Hadler groaned in response, barely managing to prop himself up against the edge of the sofa. “Dario,” he replied, his voice a rough rasp.

Dario wasted no time diving into the story. “You missed quite the spectacle last night,” he began, his grin widening. “Seems like you and Andrew had a bit of a late-night adventure. I heard you got into a bar fight—Andrew played the hero and helped you fend off the ruffians.”

Hadler’s eyes narrowed in a mix of embarrassment and pain. “A bar fight?” he croaked. “What else happened?”

Dario’s grin widened, and he continued, “Oh, it was a full-blown escapade. After the scuffle, you insisted on welcoming Andrew as a fellow captain on the *Resolute*. When Henry, our head of Operations, got woken up by your late-night call, he politely informed you that there wasn’t room for another captain. You weren’t having any of it. ‘Bullshit!’ you declared, and next thing we know, you and Andrew are off on a drunken scavenger hunt around the docking ring.”

Hadler’s aching head struggled to piece together the fragments of memory. The late-night call, the frantic search for a sofa, and the escalating chaos began to fall into place. Dario’s recounting painted a vivid picture of the night’s mayhem.

“And then?” Hadler prompted, wincing as he tried to adjust his position.

“Then,” Dario said, his tone growing a touch more serious, “we got word of the fight and the state you were in. The crew rallied to help. We escorted you and Andrew back to the sub, and at your insistence, we loaded the sofa into your cabin. The story of last night is already starting to grow more exaggerated by the crew, but that’s the gist of it.”

Hadler managed a weak chuckle despite the pain radiating through his side. “Sounds like quite the adventure.”

“More like a drunken mess,” Dario corrected, his grin never fading. “But you’ve got to admit, it’s a hell of a story.”

Hadler nodded, forcing the corners of his mouth to twitch upwards in a semblance of a smile. “I guess I’ll have to be more careful next time. For now, though, get Andrew up and moving. We’ve got work to do.”

Dario gave a nod, the grin never fully disappearing. “Will do, Captain. Rest up. We’ll handle the rest.”

As Dario left the room, Hadler took a deep breath, wincing as the pain in his side flared anew. He stared at the old, lumpy sofa—now an unexpected addition to his cabin. Despite the discomfort and the chaos, a wry smile crept onto his face. The night had been a mess, a grotesque display of the unpredictable and absurd nature of life on Europa. The remnants of the bar fight, the injuries, and the bizarre addition of a battered sofa were all part of the rough, raw reality he navigated every day. Even amidst the chaos, there was a strange, grim satisfaction in knowing that despite it all, he was still in the thick of it, ready to face whatever came next.

Elsewhere on the ship, Second electrical engineer Galveston has a moment while helping 3rd mechanic Olstein Ortega, dry swap a failing pump, "I'll never forget that night. Just past 0200, we'd been docked at this Station for a while now right?, the usual drudgery of us night crew hollowing the cargo bay 02A of that bloody lot of creates. Routine checks, nothing special. Then, outta nowhere, there's this godawful racket by the hatch. So, naturally, I go check it out, and what do I see? Captain Hadler, bleeding from the side. Literal knife still sticking out of him, absolutely shite-faced, dragging along some other ancient sea dog who looked like he hadn't seen dry land in decades. And, between them? The ugliest, most God-forsaken sofa I've ever laid eyes on. I swear, it looked like it had survived a nuclear blast and then gotten spat out by a trash compactor.

But here's the kicker—it was *real* furniture, honest-to-God, cushions and everything. And they're both stumbling around, barely able to stand, yet somehow still managing to lug this cursed couch between them like it was their last hope for salvation. The blasted thing looked heavy and it was weaving around on their shoulders like a belly dancer, Captain's shouting at poor Halverson, who's on watch duty, 'Get us in before the station cops catch us!' Halverson, bless his heart, just stood there, probably wondering if this was some kind of test. Salute? Lock the hatch? Drag the captain inside before the station cops showed up and made it *really* awkward?

Next thing I know, the hatch opens, and in they go—sofa and all, like they'd just brought back the Holy Grail. Halverson looked like he might faint on the spot, but who's gonna argue with the captain when he's half-dead, drunk as a skunk, and hauling in contraband furniture?

Later, I hear from one of the gunners—Gepp, I think—who said the station cops had called in reinforcements to break up a brawl, thinking they'd have to haul our good ol' Captain out of trouble. Only to find out that Captain Hadler and that old geezer had *already* handled it. Just the two of them, like a pair of drunk, bloodied gods of war, laying waste to six grizzled miners in a bar fight. Miners, mind you! Those guys could crack rocks with their fists. But there they were, flat on their backs, while our captain stumbles out with the world's ugliest sofa, grinning like a madman, bloody and victorious.

I haven't seen anything like it before or since. The sofa, by the way? Last I heard the captain insisted it got hauled up to his quarters and it's still there I think. I heard from Jenna in the mess, the old geezer that came back with the captain was the guy we're working for, if he helped the captain out in the fight I guess he's one of the good ones "

Hadler winced as he attempted to sit up, his side flaring with a fresh surge of pain. He took a deep breath, forced himself to ignore the throbbing headache, and began to clean himself up. He stripped off his torn and stained clothes, his movements slow and deliberate. The damaged fabric was discarded in a corner of the room, a reminder of the previous night's chaos.

The bathroom was small but functional. Hadler filled the sink with cool water and carefully cleaned the grime and blood from his skin, wincing as the cold water hit his injuries. He took a moment to examine the hastily applied bandage on his side, its edges beginning to peel away. With a grimace, he rewrapped it as best as he could, mindful of the pain that flared with every movement.

As he worked, he heard a groggy moan from the sofa. Andrew stirred, blinking slowly as he tried to make sense of his surroundings. He groaned again, shifting uncomfortably before his eyes finally focused on Hadler.

"Morning," Hadler said, his voice hoarse. He tried to sound casual, but the strain was evident.

Andrew pushed himself up, wincing as he gingerly touched the sore spots on his body.

"Morning, Captain," he replied, his voice thick with sleep and confusion. "What happened last night?"

Hadler finished cleaning up and leaned against the edge of his desk, looking at Andrew with a mixture of concern and resignation. "From what Dario told me, we got ourselves into a bit of trouble. We were in the 'Salted Kipper'—a bar down by the docks. Seems a group of drunk miners took exception to us, or maybe just to the name of sub captains in general."

Andrew's face twisted in a frown as he remembered. "Ah, yes. I recall something about that. They were angry—mumbling about how sub captains always thought they were above everyone else. It got ugly quickly."

“Yeah,” Hadler said with a sigh, “it escalated from there. You stepped in, helped fend off the ruffians. I’m not sure what I would have done without you.”

Andrew nodded, rubbing his bruised face. “It was a mess. They were miners—angry and drunk. They had some kind of grudge against captains, and it didn’t help that we might have had a few too many drinks ourselves. They were ready to throw fists over anything.”

Hadler grunted in agreement, still feeling the aftermath of the night’s events. “Well, we got out of it, at least. But now we have to deal with the fallout. We’ve got that meeting scheduled this morning. We need to figure out our next steps.”

Andrew, now more alert, nodded in understanding. “Right. What’s on the agenda?”

Hadler began to prepare for the meeting, organizing his notes and checking the schedule. “We need to review our operational status, finalize the upcoming mission details, and make sure we’re prepared for anything that might come up. I’ve got a feeling we’re not done dealing with surprises.”

Andrew rubbed his eyes, the reality of the situation settling in. “Understood. I’ll be there. Just let me get cleaned up and we can head over.”

Hadler gave a curt nod, turning his attention to the preparations. “Do what you need to. I’ll meet you at the conference room in twenty minutes.”

As Andrew shuffled off to the bathroom, Hadler took a moment to reflect on the night’s chaos. The brutal reality of life on Europa had struck again, with the ruffians representing a microcosm of the constant struggles faced by those living on the edge of survival. He thought about the mission ahead and the potential dangers lurking beneath the surface.

Despite the discomfort and the harshness of the night’s events, Hadler knew he had to press on. The unpredictable, grim nature of life on Europa demanded resilience and adaptability. With a final check of his preparations, he made his way to the conference room, ready to face whatever challenges awaited.

Captain Hadler sat in the cramped conference room, a steaming cup of coffee in hand, his fingers brushing against the warm ceramic as he waited for his department heads to trickle in. The pounding in his skull had faded to a dull throb, but the weight of the task ahead still bore down on him like an anchor dragging through the depths.

The ship was a mess of noise and activity; the crew worked tirelessly to unload the last of their cargo in the cramped docking bay, their movements a frantic dance of coordinated exhaustion. At least that part of the job was almost behind them, but as Hadler sipped his coffee, he knew the real challenge still loomed large on the horizon.

He glanced at the clock on the bulkhead. The department heads would be here any moment. Behind them, the weight of the mission pressed down. **Clearing the nest**—a cave system

crawling with hostile life forms, a deadly task with no room for error. And worse yet, the caves were above the mining colony, meaning they couldn't just collapse the whole thing in on itself like they might have in other circumstances. It would be a long, slow fight, and they'd have to map out every inch of the labyrinthine caverns to ensure nothing was left behind to resurface later.

The door slid open with a hiss, and the heads of security, operations, engineering, and medical filed in, each of them looking equally as worn and harried as the captain felt. Andrew Keflars followed them in, his face set in a grim mask of determination. There was no turning back now—not with him here as a witness, and not with the European Society for Safety (ESS) breathing down their necks. Hadler had the uneasy feeling that Andrews had come along not just as an observer, but as a silent judge of their competence.

He cleared his throat as they all took their seats. "Alright, let's get started," Hadler began, his voice hoarse from the lingering aftereffects of last night. He set his coffee down and looked around the table, meeting each of their eyes in turn. "We're nearly done with the unloading, but that's just the start of our problems. As you know, we've got a mission lined up. Crawlers in a cave system. We've been asked to clear them out—every last one."

Hadler watched as a ripple of unease spread through the room. Dario, his head of security, leaned back in his chair with a grim expression. Eddie, his chief engineer, drummed his fingers nervously on the table. Chride, the ship's doctor, furrowed his brow in thought, clearly already considering the medical ramifications of the upcoming mission. Henry, the head of operations, sat in stiff silence, his gaze focused somewhere far beyond the walls of the room.

"We've got a lot to do before we even get there," Hadler continued, pressing on before anyone could voice their concerns. "First, we need to make sure the ship's combat-ready. I want every system double-checked. That means weapons, propulsion, sonar, everything. If something's off by even a hair, we'll fix it. I won't have us going into this with any vulnerabilities."

Eddie nodded, his face set in a determined scowl. "We'll make sure everything's in top shape, Captain. But the hull—after that last upgrade—it's sturdy, but it's not invincible. If we're diving deep, we'll need to keep an eye on it."

"I know," Hadler said, rubbing his temples. "Do what you need to. Just make sure we're ready."

Dario leaned forward, his eyes dark. "And the crew? What about them? They've been working non-stop since we docked. They're going to be tired. Worn out. Not exactly the best condition to go hunting crawlers."

"I'm aware of that," Hadler replied sharply. "That's why I need you to run drills. Get them ready. Make sure they're sharp. We've got a window of time once the cargo's offloaded. Use it wisely. I'll see that we at least get one full night and day before engaging in combat."

Chride, the doctor, chimed in next. "And what about casualties, Captain? Crawlers aren't exactly known for their hospitality. We need to be ready for injuries—serious ones. If we're down in

those caves for a while, we'll need to set up a proper medical post. And I'll need to make sure we have enough supplies on hand."

"We'll be prepared for that," Hadler said. "I want a small medical team on standby, ready to deploy with the security teams. We'll do this by the book. Slow and steady."

Andrew, who had been silent until now, finally spoke up. "Captain," he said, his voice carrying the weight of years spent in this harsh, unforgiving environment, "you're right to be cautious. This isn't just another extermination mission. The cave network is larger than we initially thought. The first crew we sent in—young, eager kids—they never stood a chance. The feeds we got back were... disturbing. The crawlers didn't just defend their territory. They hunted. Ambushed. This nest—it's more than just a few beasts. It's a fortress. And it's right above this colony. Over the next few hours I'll provide your security team with all the information and readings we've got from the first ship. Before it went dark."

The room fell into a heavy silence as Andrew's words sunk in. Hadler looked at his department heads, noting the tension in their eyes. The stakes were higher than any of them had anticipated. This wasn't just a job. It was a fight for survival. One that another submarine had already failed.

"We're going to do this right," Hadler said, his voice steely. "I don't care how long it takes. We'll clear those caves. And we'll do it without losing anyone. Not this time."

The heads around the table nodded in grim agreement. There was no turning back now.

"Get your teams ready," Hadler ordered. "Once the cargo's offloaded, we move out. This is going to be messy, but we'll get it done. Dismissed."

As his department heads filed out of the room, Hadler stayed behind for a moment, staring down at the table. The weight of the mission pressed down on him, but there was no room for doubt. Europa didn't care about his fears. It demanded results.

Andrew lingered for a moment by the door, catching Hadler's eye. "You've got a good crew, Captain," he said quietly. "But this is going to test all of us. Just... be ready."

Hadler nodded, his face hard as stone. "We'll be ready."

As Andrew left, Hadler took a deep breath and stood up. There was no time for hesitation. The mission ahead was dangerous, perhaps more than any they'd faced before. But they would face it together. They would survive.

Captain Hadler lingered in the now-empty conference room, the cold metal walls reflecting the weight of the mission ahead. Andrew's words clung to him like a bad smell, his mind replaying the broken feeds of those young crews torn apart in the dark. His gut churned with the sour taste of fear, but there was no time for hesitation. Fear could fester like an open wound on Europa, and if you didn't treat it quick, it would eat you alive.

With a final swig of his stale coffee, he set the empty cup aside and steeled himself. Dwelling on the dread wouldn't save them. Europa had no patience for second thoughts, and neither did the mission. All that mattered was survival, and keeping his crew alive through another hellish ordeal.

Leaving the room, Hadler navigated the cramped, dim corridors of the Resolute. The ship vibrated with a tense energy—machinery humming, the muffled voices of crew echoing down the passageways, punctuated by the clang of tools and hurried footsteps. The Resolute was an iron behemoth, readying itself for battle, and the ship seemed to mirror the crew's own anxiety. He could feel the unspoken tension in the air, the uncertainty hanging thick over everything. It was the quiet before the storm, and it was the same every time. He was no stranger to that feeling—but it didn't make it any easier to bear.

First stop: the armory. The room smelled of oil and gunpowder, the tang of readiness that only came when people were preparing to kill or be killed. Dario was overseeing the final checks, his sharp eyes scanning the rows of weapons with the meticulousness of a man who knew that a jammed railgun could be the difference between life and death.

"Captain," Dario greeted as Hadler approached. His voice was low and edged with that familiar grim determination. "We're just about wrapped up. The gunners are running drills, and every last round has been counted and recounted. We'll be ready to drop into the pit when you give the word."

Hadler looked over the neatly stacked rows of weapons. Each one gleamed under the harsh lights, all polished and prepped for the fight ahead. His mind flashed to the caves, the dark twisting tunnels they were about to dive into, teeming with god-knows-what. They'd need every round, every inch of steel to come out alive.

"Good," Hadler said, his voice level despite the weight pressing down on him. "Keep everyone sharp. This isn't just another run-of-the-mill extermination. Andrew's reports paint a pretty bleak picture. We'll be facing more than a few ugly bugs. It's a whole nest. They'll come at us from every direction."

Dario's jaw clenched as he nodded. "The crew's tired, Captain. But they know what's at stake. I've been getting questions, though. They know something's off. They can feel it."

Hadler smirked—a dry, bitter smile. "Good. Let them feel it. Let them know what we're heading into. I'm not sugarcoating this one. If they want to survive, they'll stay sharp. We stick to the plan, follow every protocol, and we'll make it through."

"Understood, Captain," Dario replied. "I'll pass the word."

Leaving the armory behind, Hadler made his way down to engineering. Chief Engineer Eddie was waist-deep in some maintenance hatch, cursing under his breath as he tightened bolts and fiddled with wires. Sweat and oil streaked his face, but there was a familiar grin there

too—Eddie thrived in these moments, like a man playing poker with the devil, always one step ahead of disaster.

“Engines are purring like a kitten, Captain,” Eddie said, wiping his hands on a rag as he climbed out of the hatch. “She’s ready to dive headfirst into whatever hell we’re about to drop into.”

Hadler grunted in acknowledgment. “Let’s hope so. Double-check the ballast systems. We’re going deep, and we can’t afford any surprises down there. One leak, one malfunction, and we’re all fish food.”

Eddie’s grin widened slightly, though his eyes were serious. “You got it, Captain. We’ll make sure everything’s locked up tighter than a nun’s purse.”

Finally, Hadler made his way to the medical bay. The sterile, white walls stood out in stark contrast to the rest of the ship, but even the clean smell of disinfectant couldn’t erase the grim reality of what was coming. Chride was busy prepping trauma kits, his team moving like clockwork around him. They were the unsung heroes of every mission, patching up the living and counting the dead, all while pretending they weren’t one bad day away from being patients themselves.

“Captain,” Chride greeted with a quiet nod. “We’re stocked up and ready. I’ve prepped the kits, got a team ready to deploy with the security teams. But... I’ve seen the footage, too. If things go sideways, we’re going to be in for a long, ugly fight.”

Hadler met Chride’s gaze, his expression hard. “We’ll be smart. Methodical. We’ll make it through. That’s all we can do.”

Chride nodded, though the doubt lingered in his eyes. “I just hope it’s enough.”

Hadler stood there for a moment longer, watching Chride’s team as they worked. They moved with quiet efficiency, every action practiced and precise. The specter of death hung over them, but they didn’t flinch. They’d been through hell before, and they’d make it through again—or at least, that’s what Hadler had to tell himself.

Leaving the med bay, Hadler made his way back to the bridge. The hum of the ship seemed louder now, every vibration and creak a reminder of the looming mission. The bridge was a familiar sight, consoles and screens flickering with data, the command seat sitting at the center of it all. His seat. His burden.

Hadler sank into the chair, feeling the weight of the ship settle around him like a lead blanket. The next few days would be hell, no doubt about it. But they’d survived worse. Europa hadn’t killed them yet.

“Status report,” Hadler called out, his voice carrying the weight of command.

Henry, the head of operations, glanced over from his station. “We’re nearly done with the cargo. Engineering reports all systems green. Weapons are prepped and loaded. We’re ready to depart as soon as we get the all-clear.”

Hadler nodded, his fingers drumming on the armrest. The moment of truth was fast approaching. They were diving headfirst into the abyss, into the jaws of whatever nightmares awaited them in those dark, winding caves. But for now, all he could do was wait. Wait, and prepare.

It took a grueling day and a half to offload the cargo, a day and a half of delays, breakdowns, and frayed nerves. The crew was running on fumes, pushing through sheer exhaustion as they unloaded crate after crate in the cramped, freezing dock. Hadler made sure Jenna was prepping extra rations while they were at port. It cost them extra, but it was worth it. They’d need every last bit of energy for what lay ahead.

As the final cargo crates were offloaded, Hadler felt a strange calm settle over him. The storm was coming, and they were walking straight into it—but he was ready. They all were. Andrew’s grim tales still echoed in his mind, but they had a plan now. They knew what they were walking into, and that was half the battle.

With a final confirmation from the docking bay, the cargo was offloaded, and the Resolute was free to depart.

“Alright,” Hadler said, his voice cutting through the tension on the bridge. “Let’s get this done.”

The Resolute lurched into motion, the engines roaring to life as the ship began its descent into the icy depths. The next day would be tense—everyone knowing they were sailing into more than just a routine mission. This was about more than clearing out hostile lifeforms. It was about avenging the lost, the young, the ones who had gone into those caves and never come back. The crew knew it, and so did Hadler.

This wasn’t just another job. It was revenge.

The Resolute slipped out of port with the smooth efficiency of a well-oiled machine. The pneumatic shunt did its job flawlessly, and the ship glided away from the dockside without a hitch. There wasn’t even a peep from engineering—a reassuring sign that everything was functioning as it should be. The familiar farewell message played over the comms, a jaunty little tune that now seemed out of place, almost hollow against the backdrop of the grim mission that lay ahead.

Hadler stood on the bridge, the sense of revenge in the air palpable even if he tried to downplay it. Andrew, now a somber and necessary companion for this voyage, stood by his side. The crew had absorbed the gravity of their task: not just a routine extermination of hostile lifeforms, but a rare chance for retribution against the creatures that had claimed the lives of fellow submariners. The loss of those young lives—dreamers who had once envisioned themselves as intrepid explorers—now fueled a deep-seated anger and resolve among his own crew.

The typical morale boost of the farewell tune did little to lighten the mood. The truth was, no submarine crew enjoyed hearing about a ship that had fallen prey to the deep's malevolent inhabitants. The idea of avenging a lost submarine, while rare and intoxicating, also carried its own set of dangers. Hadler knew that stoking the fires of vengeance could be a double-edged sword. He needed his crew to be angry, but he also needed them to be disciplined and focused.

The line between righteous fury and reckless abandon was thin, and it was one that Hadler had to tread carefully. He was all too aware of the risk of pushing them too hard, of unleashing a bloodlust that could cloud their judgment. The crew was already running on fumes, their energy sapped by the exhausting push to unload the cargo and prepare for departure. They were tired, their nerves frayed, and the last thing they needed was a mission that turned their anger into a dangerous, uncontrolled force.

Hadler needed them calm, controlled, and most importantly, ready to follow the plan. He'd seen what happened when a crew got too hot-headed—too many times, it ended with unnecessary casualties and a botched mission. The deep was unforgiving enough without adding self-inflicted chaos to the mix.

So, as the *Resolute* sailed into the icy void, Hadler made a conscious effort to temper the crew's fiery resolve with steady, rational leadership. They would have their vengeance, but it would be measured, precise, and by the book. They would strike when the time was right, and not a moment sooner. In the cold, dark depths of Europa, with every shadow hiding potential peril, the only way to ensure survival was through calculated action and unwavering discipline.

He knew that if he could manage to harness their anger without letting it control them, if he could balance their need for retribution with the necessity of staying sharp and focused, they might just make it through this alive.

As the *Resolute* eased into its post-docking routine, Captain Hadler and his command crew convened in the strategy room, a space lit by the dim glow of console screens and the soft hum of the ship's systems. The room was filled with a palpable sense of urgency and focus as they began the intricate task of planning their descent into the icy depths.

Hadler, with a furrowed brow, laid out the mission parameters. The navigator, a grizzled veteran with a sharp eye for detail, meticulously mapped out the route from their current position to a point within dive range of the known entrance to the cave complex. The route was plotted with precision, accounting for potential hazards and required maneuvers. Every twist and turn, every change in depth was considered to ensure a smooth and safe journey.

"Alright," Hadler said, pointing to the map on the screen, "we need to chart a course that gets us close enough to the entrance without risking the ship. What's our projected approach distance?"

The navigator responded, eyes fixed on the data. "We'll need to maintain a steady course and avoid any abrupt changes. Given the terrain, we should plan for a gradual descent. The entrance is well within reach if we stick to the plotted course."

Dario, head of security, stepped forward, his expression serious. "We'll need to coordinate our turret sweeps as we approach. I suggest we schedule regular sweeps to cover all potential angles of attack. I'll have the gunners assigned to the ship's defense cover the entrance while the dive team handles the recovery operations."

Hadler nodded, glancing at the list of gunners. "Which gunners will be part of the dive team?"

Dario tapped the screen, highlighting the names. "Gunnars Miller and Ross will join the dive team. They're experienced and can handle the pressures of both the dive and the potential for combat. The others will stay behind for perimeter defense and to cover the ship."

With a plan forming, Hadler turned to the remaining department heads. "We'll need additional support for the dive operations. How many of the other crew members can be assigned to ferrying oxygen bottles, medical equipment, lighting, and sonar beacons?"

Chief Engineer Eddie and Chief of Operations Henry exchanged looks before Eddie spoke up. "We've got a few engineers and techs available for support roles. They can handle the logistics of moving equipment and ensuring that everything runs smoothly. We should also prepare for establishing a forward operating recharge station. It'll be crucial if the dive extends beyond our current estimates."

Henry added, "The complex is larger than initially expected, and we should plan for extended operations. We'll need to ensure that all equipment and personnel are prepared for a prolonged stay."

Hadler acknowledged their input with a nod. "Understood. We'll also need to dispatch a smaller dive team to handle the recovery of the wrecked ship at the entrance. Their mission will be to retrieve the bodies and recover the Listania's keel plate and captain's log. This will give us additional context and potentially crucial data."

The team set to work, assigning roles and responsibilities with methodical precision. The dive team was briefed on their objectives, and support crew members were directed to prepare the necessary equipment. The tension in the room was tempered by the steady rhythm of preparation, each crew member moving with a purpose.

As the final details were hammered out, Hadler took a moment to review the plan in its entirety. The Resolute was about to embark on a mission fraught with peril, but with meticulous preparation and clear communication, they stood a better chance of navigating the dangers ahead.

"Let's get this done," Hadler said, his voice firm and resolute. "We're heading into unknown territory, and every detail counts. Stay sharp, follow the plan, and we'll come through this. We owe it to those who've come before us, and we owe it to ourselves."

The crew dispersed to carry out their assigned tasks, the ship's atmosphere thick with a blend of anticipation and resolve. The time for preparation was ending; the time for action was approaching. With the dive plan in place and the crew primed for the challenge, the Resolute prepared to dive into the depths of Europa's icy waters, ready to confront whatever lay hidden in the darkness.

The Resolute emerged from the perpetual darkness of the deep as it approached the dive point, a cold, unyielding stretch of Europa's icy waters. The slow, deliberate descent had allowed the crew a precious night of rest, a brief respite before the impending ordeal. The captain's decision to ease into the dive point had been strategic—a measure to drain the hot-blooded desires that might have driven the crew into reckless decisions.

The transition from their slow, steady course to the dive point was marked by an eerie stillness, the hum of the ship's systems providing the only semblance of life against the oppressive silence. The icy water enveloped the Resolute like a cold, suffocating shroud, its murky depths a constant reminder of the danger that lurked just beyond the hull.

Captain Hadler stood on the bridge, his eyes scanning the sensors and displays as the ship approached its destination. The routine of the last day had been almost hypnotic—the steady, rhythmic thrum of the engines, the low murmur of the crew's conversations, and the ever-present sound of the water's cold embrace. The crew, having had a chance to rest, now moved with a grim resolve, their faces etched with the weariness of anticipation and the grim determination of those who knew the stakes.

The corridors of the Resolute, usually vibrant with the hum of activity, seemed to hold their breath as the ship neared the dive point. The cold, oppressive silence was punctuated only by the occasional clink of metal and the distant hiss of pressurized air. The crew moved in measured, deliberate motions, each step echoing with the weight of the mission ahead.

Hadler took a final, steadying breath, bracing himself for the task at hand. The deep, oppressive cold of the water seemed to seep into the very bones of the ship, a constant reminder of the hostile environment they were about to confront. He turned to his crew, each member a picture of grim determination.

"Prepare for dive operations," Hadler commanded, his voice cutting through the stillness. "This is it. We're going in."

The crew responded with practiced efficiency, each member falling into their roles with a quiet intensity. The gunners prepared their equipment, the engineers made final checks, and the medical team ensured that all supplies were in place. The familiar, sterile scent of the medical bay mingled with the cold, metallic tang of the ship's interior, a reminder of the danger and the cold reality of their mission.

As the Resolute reached the designated dive point, the crew gathered in the dive bay, ready for the descent into the abyss. The murky, oppressive waters loomed outside, a vast, dark expanse that swallowed the light and held its secrets close.

Hadler's eyes met those of his crew, each face a mask of steely resolve. "We've planned for every contingency, but remember this—staying calm and focused is the key. We stick to the plan, follow procedures, and keep our wits about us."

Andrew, standing beside Hadler, gave a curt nod. His presence, though grim, was a reminder of the reality they faced—a firsthand witness to the horrors that lay below.

As the dive team prepared to descend, Hadler took one last look at the Resolute, the ship that had become their fortress and their sanctuary. The icy waters of Europa, cold and indifferent, awaited them. The shadows of the deep were not forgiving, and the dangers they would face were real and tangible. But they were ready.

With a final, resolute breath, Hadler turned to face the crew. "Let's get this done."

The hatch to the dive bay opened, and the team began their descent into the depths. The water closed around them, the murky darkness swallowing the light as they plunged into the unknown. The cold, oppressive silence of the abyss enveloped them, a constant reminder of the peril that lay ahead.

The Resolute, now a distant silhouette against the icy expanse, held its breath as the crew ventured into the darkness. The mission had begun, and the time for action was upon them. The darkness of Europa's depths was waiting, and the crew was ready to face whatever lay hidden in the cold, unforgiving void.

Captain Hadler stood at the bridge, his gaze fixed on the dark expanse of the abyss as the crew descended into the depths. The ship's thrumming engines, once a reassuring background hum, now seemed almost to pulse in sync with the oppressive silence that enveloped them. He monitored the comms chatter with a growing sense of unease as the dive teams engaged with their first contacts.

The initial reports came in sporadically, voices breaking through the static, each transmission tinged with the tension of first contact. The underwater gunfire, though muted by the vast, cold depths, carried an unsettling rhythm that underscored the danger they faced. The telltale thermal blooms on the sensors revealed swarms of hostile forms lurking just beyond the reach of their illumination, a chaotic dance of heat signatures that spoke volumes of the peril awaiting the teams below.

Hadler's eyes darted across the screens, the scenes of the wrecked ship coming into view. The salvage operations were underway, a methodical process marked by the steady hum of machinery and the quiet voices of the team leaders coordinating their efforts. The sound of cutting tools and the occasional creak of metal were punctuated by the muffled voices of the dive teams, their calm and collected tones belying the chaos of their environment.

"Command, this is Dive Team Alpha," came the voice of the team leader, crisp and controlled despite the evident strain. "We're approaching the wreck. Initial scans show significant damage, but we're beginning salvage operations now."

Hadler nodded, his gaze focused on the live feed from the dive team's cameras. The wrecked ship, once a symbol of the lost, now loomed as a grim reminder of the dangers that lay below. The decayed bodies of the previous crew were carefully recovered, each retrieval a somber task that spoke to the brutality of the forces they were dealing with.

As Dive Team Bravo began their efforts to cut through the resistance in the nearby cavern, Hadler's attention was drawn to the tense moments of calm communications interspersed with the sharp bursts of underwater gunfire. The gunners on the surface were struggling against the sheer numbers of abominations that surged forth, their efforts marked by the occasional flicker of panic in their voices.

"Command, we've got a situation here," reported Dario over the comms, his tone carrying a note of grim amusement. "We're being overrun, and the gunners are getting pushed hard. I've got a solution for you."

Hadler's brow furrowed as he listened, his thoughts racing through the possible implications. Dario's grin was almost palpable through the comms, his confidence a stark contrast to the tension that had settled over the bridge.

"Deploying grenades," Dario announced, his voice carrying a mixture of satisfaction and urgency. "Small, low-yield fragmentation. Not enough to do significant damage, but they should provide the punch we need to clear out the heavier crowds. Time to pop our party favors and give those abominations something to think about."

Hadler's eyes narrowed as he considered the implications. The use of grenades was a calculated risk, a move designed to shift the tide of battle but with potential for unintended consequences. Still, the crew needed every advantage they could get. The tension in the command center was palpable as the order was relayed, and the sounds of the gunners preparing their grenades reached Hadler's ears.

"Alright," Hadler said, his voice steady despite the gravity of the situation. "Let's see how this plays out. Keep me updated on the progress."

As the grenades were deployed, the underwater explosions provided a much-needed respite, the concussions sending shockwaves through the cavern and momentarily disrupting the onslaught of abominations. The comms chatter became a mix of relieved exclamations and

urgent updates as the dive teams pressed forward, their movements a blend of determination and strategic precision.

Hadler remained at his post, his gaze fixed on the screens as the scene unfolded before him. The battle was far from over, but the tide had shifted, if only slightly. The cold, dark waters of Europa held their secrets close, and the crew faced a daunting task. Yet, despite the grim reality, a flicker of hope remained—hope that they would prevail, that they would make it through the abyss and achieve their objective.

The Resolute continued its vigil above, the weight of the mission pressing heavily on Hadler's shoulders. Each moment was a testament to the crew's resilience, their ability to adapt and overcome. As the battle raged below, Hadler's resolve hardened. They would face whatever came next with the same grim determination that had carried them this far.

Captain Hadler, seated at the command console, observed the descent of his crew with a mix of tension and grim determination. The murky, claustrophobic depths of Europa seemed to press in on the Resolute, an ever-present reminder of the treacherous mission at hand. As the submarine's lights pierced the darkness, revealing the wrecked hull of the lost Listania, the captain's thoughts churned with unease.

The comms chatter crackled with the frenetic energy of first contact with the enemy. The voices of his crew, though calm and methodical, betrayed the tension of the moment. The initial sounds of underwater gunfire punctuated the stillness, each burst of muted noise a stark reminder of the battle raging just beyond their reach. The thermal sensors displayed a chaotic dance of blooms—signs of the enemy's presence, surging and retreating as their dive teams made contact with the abominations within the caves.

The salvage operation on the wrecked Listania was painstaking. The team, equipped with heavy-duty cutting tools, worked meticulously to retrieve the bodies and valuable components. Each piece of the decimated ship, from the keel plate to the captain's log, was handled with reverence and precision. The slow, methodical process was a necessary counterpoint to the violence unfolding in the caverns nearby.

In the cavern network, the crawl space was alive with hostile movement. The gunners' efforts were relentless but increasingly strained as the sheer numbers of crawlers pressed against their defenses. The comms lines crackled with terse commands and the gritted responses of those on the front lines.

Hadler's eyes were drawn to the tense moments of silence between bursts of radio traffic, each pause a heavy breath before the next onslaught. The crew's struggle was palpable, their voices tinged with the strain of holding back a tide of monstrous opposition. The underwater gunfire was a dull roar in the background, a constant reminder of the chaos that lay just outside the safety of their hull.

Then, amidst the grim chatter, Dario's voice cut through with a new edge of excitement. "Captain, I've authorized the deployment of grenades. Small, low-yield fragmentation. They'll

give our gunners a much-needed boost against the heavier crowds. Not enough to collapse the caves, but enough to clear the way.”

Hadler’s jaw tightened as he absorbed the news. He made a mental note to address Dario’s unilateral decision later; such matters required consultation, not surprises. However, he recognized the necessity of the move. Andrew, ever the seasoned observer, seemed to process the situation with a mixture of doubt and reluctant approval. The grenades would enhance their firepower without breaching the rule of not using explosives to collapse the cave system.

The reality of the situation was clear: the caves were fragile and dangerous, their structural integrity precarious at best. Using explosives could easily trigger a catastrophic collapse. But, as Hadler watched the unfolding battle, he knew that sometimes calculated risks were the only option when facing overwhelming odds.

“Deploy the grenades,” Hadler instructed, his voice steady despite the roiling uncertainty within. “But remind the teams to use them wisely. We need to clear the crawlers, not bring down the whole cave.”

As the orders were relayed, Hadler allowed himself a moment to reflect. The crew’s grim determination and the slow, methodical progress in the face of relentless danger were testament to their resolve. This was not just a mission of survival—it was a mission to honor the lost and to reclaim their lost dignity from the abyss. If they were to make it through, they would need every ounce of their strength and every tool at their disposal.

As the team completed the meticulous task of clearing the wrecked Listania, the atmosphere in the comms room was thick with the weight of their grim procession. Each item recovered, whether it was a pallet of bodies or a crate of reactor fuel and munitions, bore the heavy mark of sacrifice and loss.

The salvage team, moving with a deliberate and somber efficiency, worked through the wreckage. The bodies, once young and full of potential, were recovered with respect, each one a silent testament to the cruel fate that had befallen them. They were transported with care, their final resting places now becoming part of the ship’s grim cargo. The captain, observing from the command console, felt the sting of their fate acutely, knowing that these were lives cut short in the pursuit of a dangerous dream.

The recovered reactor fuel and munitions were carefully loaded onto the Resolute. The cargo holds filled with these crucial supplies were a stark reminder of the risks and demands of deep-space salvage. The reactor fuel, though vital for their operations, came with its own set of dangers. The munitions, while essential for their defense, symbolized the violent confrontation that lay ahead.

The comms chatter was a muted hum of efficient coordination. Team leaders relayed updates on their progress, their voices betraying the exhaustion of the ongoing battle. The sound of underwater gunfire had become a constant backdrop, its rhythmic thud a reminder of the ever-present threat lurking in the dark.

As the salvage operation concluded, Hadler took a moment to review the status of their dive teams and the cave network. The command center buzzed with activity, the staff coordinating the final phases of their mission. The divers, now weary but resolute, prepared for the next phase: clearing the cave system of the abominations that had claimed the Listania and its crew.

Dario's tactical update came through. "Captain, the grenades have made a significant difference. We've managed to push back some of the heavier crowds. The teams are making headway, but we're still facing stiff resistance. The cave system is more complex than anticipated. We're encountering more abominations than expected."

Hadler acknowledged the report, his mind racing with calculations and strategies. "Understood. Maintain the pressure, but keep an eye on the structural integrity of the caves. We need to balance aggression with caution. The last thing we need is a cave-in on top of us."

As the final recovery efforts wrapped up, the salvaged items were secured in the hold. The Listania's wreckage, now stripped of its valuable components, was left behind. The Resolute's crew prepared to move forward, the weight of their mission pressing down on them like the icy depths surrounding their vessel.

With the salvage complete, the crew's focus shifted to the next phase of their operation. The caves, now more accessible thanks to the clearing efforts, awaited their exploration. The abominations that had claimed the Listania were still out there, lurking in the darkness, ready to defend their territory against any intruders.

The tension on the bridge of the Resolute was palpable as the sonar tech's urgent cry pierced through the steady hum of the ship. "Contacts! Multiple contacts approaching from the rear!"

Captain Hadler's heart sank as he recognized the familiar dread of an encircling threat. The abominations, driven out of their lairs by the fierce combat in the caves, were now attempting to flank the submarine. It was a tactic he had encountered before, a grim reminder of how the creatures adapted to their surroundings, using the terrain to their advantage.

Hadler had anticipated this possibility. Experience had taught him that underestimating the adaptability of these creatures was a fatal mistake. He had ordered sweeping patrols and perimeter defenses as a precaution, knowing full well that the caves could force the creatures into new positions.

"Status report!" Hadler's voice was steady, cutting through the comms chatter.

"Captain, we're picking up multiple thermal signatures approaching from the aft sector," the sonar tech responded, his voice calm but urgent. "The crawlers are moving fast. We've got them on the scopes, and the gunners are in position."

Hadler's mind raced, calculating the best course of action. He knew the gunners were already primed and ready. Dario's earlier deployment of grenades had fortified their defenses, providing

them with the firepower needed to handle such threats. The gunners had established a defensive perimeter, their positions well fortified against the incoming assault.

“Deploy countermeasures,” Hadler ordered, his voice carrying the weight of authority. “Initiate defensive sweeps and engage targets as soon as they come within range. We can’t afford any surprises.”

His command was met with a swift response. The gunners, well-trained and disciplined, moved with practiced efficiency. The muted thud of underwater gunfire began, punctuated by the steady cadence of railguns and coil guns finding their marks. The comms buzzed with the calm, confident voices of the gunners coordinating their efforts, each one focused on their designated sectors.

“Targets engaged. The perimeter is holding,” came the report from one of the gunners. “We’re pushing them back. No sign of breaches yet.”

Hadler observed the situation with a keen eye. The sonar displays showed the thermal blooms of the attacking creatures being systematically driven back. The gunners, equipped with their heavy weaponry and grenades, were holding the line effectively. The situation was under control, though the need for vigilance remained ever-present.

“Maintain your positions and keep the pressure on them,” Hadler commanded. “We’re dealing with a coordinated attack. Stay sharp and don’t let up.”

His instructions were followed without hesitation. The crew’s training and discipline were evident in their response. The gunners, despite the harrowing circumstances, exhibited the calm professionalism that Hadler had come to rely on. Their steady aim and controlled bursts of fire ensured that the creatures were being driven back effectively.

As the battle raged, Hadler took a moment to reflect on the precarious balance of their situation. The coordinated defense had prevented the crawlers from breaching the submarine, but the fight was far from over. The creatures continued to test their defenses, seeking any weakness to exploit.

The comms crackled with intermittent updates, the calm tones of the gunners’ voices reassuring Hadler that their defenses were holding strong. The sonar tech continued to track the movements of the crawlers, providing vital information to guide the gunners’ efforts.

The Resolute’s crew remained focused, their resolve unwavering despite the mounting pressure. Hadler knew that their success in this encounter depended on their ability to remain disciplined and precise. The creatures might be relentless, but the crew’s determination was even stronger.

“Keep the pressure on them,” Hadler repeated, his voice a steady anchor amidst the chaos. “We’re not giving them an inch.”

With the situation under control, Hadler focused on the broader mission. The defense of the submarine was crucial, but so was the ongoing salvage and exploration of the cave system. The dive teams continued their work, recovering the remains of the Listania and securing valuable equipment, all while contending with the threats emerging from the depths.

The battle with the crawlers was a reminder of the ever-present danger that lay in the abyss. But with each successful engagement, the crew's confidence grew, solidifying their resolve to see the mission through to the end.

As the final echoes of underwater gunfire faded and the distant whines of the ship's close action coil guns ceased, a tense calm settled over the Resolute. The relentless sweep of the ship's weaponry had successfully driven off the remaining crawlers outside the cave, clearing the immediate threat to the submarine.

On the bridge, Captain Hadler remained focused, his eyes fixed on the sonar displays and comms channels. The dive team's progress reports continued to filter in, painting a grim picture of the ongoing struggle within the caves. The body counts were climbing steadily, each report a stark reminder of the battle they faced.

"Captain," came the voice of the lead dive team commander over the comms, his tone steady but tinged with exhaustion. "We're making progress. We've cleared the primary threat zones, but there's heavy resistance further in. We need additional ammunition and fresh oxygen tanks. Several suits are also showing signs of wear. We've had a few minor injuries that need attention."

Hadler nodded, his mind already working through the logistical responses. "Understood. I'll coordinate with the supply teams and medical staff. Get those resupplies to the dive team as quickly as possible."

The captain's orders were executed with practiced efficiency. The supply teams began preparing additional ammunition and fresh oxygen tanks for immediate dispatch. Medical personnel rushed to tend to the minor injuries sustained by the dive team, applying first aid and performing necessary repairs on the suits. A few of the gunners were rotated out, their replacements stepping in to maintain the defensive perimeter.

Hadler continued to monitor the situation from the bridge, the steady flow of information providing him with a clear picture of the ongoing operations. The sonar tech's updates were increasingly positive; the dive team was pushing deeper into the cave system, making significant headway despite the persistent threats.

The captain's eyes flicked to the screen displaying the thermal blooms and sonar readings from the caves. The data showed the dive team's progress, the red blips of hostile creatures gradually being pushed back by their efforts. The fight was far from over, but the dive team's methodical approach was slowly turning the tide in their favor.

“Keep me updated on the dive team’s status,” Hadler instructed the sonar tech. “We need to ensure their safety and effectiveness as they continue their work. We can’t afford any more surprises.”

“Roger that, Captain,” the sonar tech responded, his fingers flying over the controls as he relayed the latest information.

The captain’s gaze shifted to the tactical display, tracking the dive team’s movements as they navigated the treacherous cave system. Each progress report, each successful sweep, was a small victory in the larger battle. Hadler knew that the key to success lay in their ability to maintain focus and discipline amidst the chaos.

As the hours wore on, the captain’s resolve remained unshaken. The dive team’s efforts were paying off, the cave system gradually being cleared of the hostile creatures. The salvage team had returned to the submarine with the recovered equipment and remains of the Listania, their grim procession a testament to the high cost of their mission.

Hadler’s thoughts were on the dive team, their safety, and the continued progress of their operations. The cave system was proving to be a formidable challenge, but the crew’s resilience and determination were evident in their every action.

“Stay vigilant,” Hadler reminded himself, watching the screens with unwavering focus. “We’ve come this far. We need to see it through to the end.”

With the dive team pressing on, the captain’s attention remained fixed on their progress. The mission was far from complete, but with each passing hour, the odds of success seemed to grow a little stronger.

Captain Hadler stood beside Andrew on the bridge, their focus locked on the screens displaying live feeds from the dive team. The tension in the room was palpable, a heavy silence occasionally broken by the hum of machinery and the soft crackle of comms chatter.

The feed from the dive team revealed a stark transformation in the cave system. The narrow tunnels had given way to larger caverns, their depths teeming with the alien marine life that Europa was infamous for. The bioluminescent flora cast an eerie glow over the scene, creating an almost surreal contrast to the grim reality of their mission.

The camera footage from inside the caves showed the team approaching what appeared to be massive chambers filled with swollen pods of crawler eggs. The sight was both fascinating and horrifying. The pods were massive, pulsating with a grotesque vitality that hinted at the horrors still to come. The presence of these egg chambers signaled a significant uptick in resistance, with hordes of crawlers—both young and old—swarming the area in a defensive frenzy.

Hadler's gaze was fixed on the screens, his mind racing as he processed the implications of what he was seeing. The crawl chambers, festooned with crawling larvae and adult beasts, presented a nightmarish landscape. The sheer number of enemies and the ferocity with which they defended their nests indicated that the dive team was now deep within the heart of the infestation.

Andrew, standing beside Hadler, broke the silence with a grim observation. "They're hitting the mother lode. This is where the real fight begins. Those egg chambers are going to be a nightmare to clear."

Hadler nodded, his expression unyielding. "We expected this level of resistance. What worries me is the sheer scale of the defense. The crawlers are organized and relentless."

The feed shifted to a closer view of the chambers, revealing a gruesome reality: the crawlers were consuming their own dead, a macabre survival tactic that had become all too familiar. The sight of the beasts feasting on the remains of their fallen kin was a stark reminder of their brutal and efficient nature. The cannibalism among the crawlers was not just a grotesque display but a strategic maneuver—an unsettling tactic that ensured no resource, not even the flesh of their own kind, went to waste.

Andrew glanced at Hadler, his face a mask of grim determination. "They're not going to make this easy for us. We need to keep pushing, keep clearing. Every inch gained is a victory."

Hadler's jaw tightened. "We'll continue to support them from here. Keep the gunners on high alert and ensure the supply teams are ready for anything. We can't afford any missteps now."

The comms channel crackled to life as the dive team leader's voice came through, steady but tinged with exhaustion. "Captain, we're encountering significant resistance. The crawlers are fiercely defending the egg chambers. We've managed to secure a perimeter, but it's slow going. We need additional support and resupply for the team."

Hadler relayed the instructions to the supply team, coordinating the delivery of additional ammunition, oxygen tanks, and medical supplies. He watched as the dive team continued their methodical assault on the egg chambers, the footage revealing the harrowing progress they were making against the relentless defenders.

The captain's gaze remained fixed on the screens, his mind focused on the tactical challenges ahead. The battle was far from over, and the true scale of the crawler infestation was only just beginning to reveal itself. Hadler knew that the dive team's endurance and skill would be put to the ultimate test in the coming hours.

As the hours wore on and the dive team pressed deeper into the cavern system, Hadler maintained a vigilant watch over their progress. The fight was becoming increasingly brutal, but with each successful sweep and each chamber cleared, the crew was inching closer to their objective.

“Keep it up,” Hadler murmured to himself, the weight of the mission heavy on his shoulders. “We’re getting closer. We just need to hold the line.”

Captain Hadler and Dario had been through their fair share of encounters with crawlers. Their experience had taught them the nuances of dealing with these nightmarish creatures. The crawlers’ behavior was both predictable and treacherous—something they had come to understand deeply.

From their previous encounters, Hadler knew that the crawlers, while formidable, had specific behavioral patterns that could be exploited. When dealing with them, the key was to manage the numbers and the waves. Each crawler was a vicious, relentless force on its own, but in packs, their dynamics shifted.

The larger groups, while initially more threatening, often became their own worst enemies. They’d come in waves, usually between three to five at a time. But when faced with a full ammo clip and disciplined fire, their initial bravery would quickly turn to confusion. The pack mentality, which drove them to swarm and attack with ruthless efficiency, fell apart when confronted with organized resistance.

The larger groups of crawlers had a tendency to break down into smaller, more chaotic skirmishes. Their internal hierarchies and social structures would collapse under the pressure of sustained fire, leading to infighting and a disorganized assault. The bigger the group, the more likely it was that the crawlers would devolve into a chaotic melee, their unity disintegrating as they turned on each other.

Dario’s voice came over the comms, calm but firm. “Captain, we’re seeing the same behavior we’ve encountered before. The large groups are starting to splinter. They’re losing their cohesion. The smaller packs are becoming easier to manage.”

Hadler nodded, his eyes scanning the screens showing the dive team’s progress. “Keep the gunners focused on the larger clusters. Once they start breaking up, it’s easier to pick them off. We need to minimize the risk of any of them getting too close.”

Dario’s response was quick, “Understood. We’re maintaining suppressive fire and focusing on the larger groups. The smaller packs are being dealt with efficiently.”

The strategy was working. The crawl chambers, despite their formidable defenses, were slowly being cleared. The chaotic behavior of the crawlers, their tendency to fall into infighting, was proving to be a critical advantage for the dive team. The disciplined approach of the gunners, combined with the captain’s strategic oversight, was beginning to tip the scales in their favor.

Hadler remained vigilant, the steady rhythm of the battle unfolding before him. The knowledge that the crawlers’ pack dynamics worked against them provided a sliver of hope amidst the grim reality of their mission. With every chamber cleared and every wave repelled, they moved one step closer to the objective—and one step closer to avenging the lost submarine and its crew.

The captain's focus never wavered. Each decision, each command, was executed with the precision that only experience could bring. The fight was far from over, but with their strategy proving effective and the team's resilience holding strong, Hadler knew they were making progress.

As the final rotation of gunners reported no more contacts on the sensors, a collective sigh of relief seemed to settle over the crew. The relentless pressure of the crawler assaults had finally eased, and the cavernous darkness was once again quiet. For the moment, the immediate threat had been neutralized.

Captain Hadler, Andrew, and Dario took a moment to shift their focus from the intense, immediate combat situation to the environment around them. The cavern's walls, once ominous and shrouded in darkness, now revealed more of their eerie details. Bioluminescent fungi glowed faintly, casting an unsettling light over the cavern's twisted, jagged formations. The wrecked ship and its gruesome cargo lay in stark contrast to the eerie beauty of the surroundings.

Henry's voice cut through the silence, a touch of exasperation masked with his usual calm. "Captain, it's been twelve hours since we began the operation. That explains the grumbling stomachs and the relative hunger around here. We could all use a break, or at least a meal."

Hadler glanced at Andrew, who looked equally worn but also quietly relieved. The tension in the room had shifted from high-stakes combat to the stark reality of their prolonged efforts. "Understood, Henry. Let's get everyone rehydrated and fed. We've earned a breather."

Dario, still grinning from the success of the operation, added, "I'll make sure the team gets a hot meal. They've earned it. We can't afford to have our people running on empty, not after everything they've been through."

Hadler nodded, his eyes scanning the cavern's interior. "Good. While the crew takes a much-needed break, let's make sure we have a comprehensive assessment of our findings. We've cleared the caves, but there's still the matter of the salvage and the remaining unknowns."

The team began to methodically check their surroundings. The initial sweep had cleared the immediate danger, but Hadler knew that a thorough inspection was crucial. They had to ensure that no hidden threats remained and that the area was fully secure before moving on.

As the crew gathered for their meals, the atmosphere lightened slightly. The stress and fatigue were palpable, but so was the relief of a job well done. Hadler, Andrew, and Dario used the time to regroup and discuss their next steps, taking stock of their surroundings and the long-term implications of their findings.

The wrecked ship's cargo was being sorted and cataloged, and the remains of the previous crew were being handled with the respect they deserved. The captain knew that while they had made significant progress, the mission was far from over. They still had to deal with the

aftermath of the operation, including the final assessment of the environment and the ongoing challenges of working in such a hostile and unpredictable setting.

For now, though, they took a moment to savor the victory. The immediate threat was gone, the caves were secured, and the crew could rest. Hadler allowed himself a brief moment of quiet satisfaction before the next wave of challenges would inevitably arise.

In the galley, the crew took their well-deserved respite. Captain Hadler, his face smeared with traces of a hastily consumed meal, looked across the table at Andrew and Dario. The strain of the mission was still evident in his eyes, but there was a hint of relief as well. Henry's voice echoed from the doorway, breaking the momentary calm.

"Captain, we've identified some promising resources near the cave entrance. There are notable concentrations of biological life that could be of use—elastin plastics, sea shrooms, slime molds, and even some pure water-deposited crystals. I think it's worth organizing an expedition to harvest these resources," Henry said, his tone practical yet imbued with an unmistakable enthusiasm for the potential gains.

Hadler wiped his mouth with a napkin, his mind already shifting gears. "That sounds promising, Henry. We need to make the most of what we've found here. Not just for the immediate benefits, but for the long-term sustainability of our operations."

Andrew nodded, having been silent for a moment as he processed the information. "The resources could be crucial for both immediate needs and future missions. Harvesting them efficiently would be a wise move."

Dario, leaning back in his chair with a satisfied grin, added, "I'll get the gunners prepped for any potential encounters while we're out there. We wouldn't want any surprises while collecting these resources."

Hadler gave a thoughtful nod. "Agreed. We'll need to ensure that the crew is fully equipped for both harvesting and any possible threats. I don't want to underestimate the environment—Europa has a way of keeping us on our toes."

Henry moved to take action, already starting to organize the necessary mechanics and logistics for the expedition. "I'll get the details sorted and make sure the team is ready. We'll need to prepare for both the recovery operations and potential encounters with local life forms."

As Henry departed to manage the preparations, Hadler finished his meal and glanced at Andrew and Dario. "It's been a long day, but there's still more to do. Let's ensure we're ready for this next phase. If these resources are as valuable as they seem, we need to approach the extraction with the same caution and efficiency we've shown so far."

Andrew, still looking contemplative, replied, "Absolutely. We've made progress, but we can't afford to let our guard down. Every step forward is a potential risk."

Dario clapped Hadler on the back. “Don’t worry, Captain. We’ll handle it. We’ve got a good team and the experience to back it up.”

Hadler managed a tired smile. “I’m counting on it. Let’s get ready for the next phase and make sure we leave no stone unturned—no matter how dark or dangerous.”

With the crew’s next steps clear, Hadler felt a renewed sense of purpose. The mission was progressing, and while the dangers were ever-present, they were navigating them with a mix of careful planning and hard-won experience. The prospect of harvesting valuable resources was a welcome opportunity, a sign that despite the grim nature of their work, there were tangible benefits to their efforts.

As Captain Hadler made his way back to his cabin, the corridors of the Resolute seemed quieter than usual. The aftermath of the mission had settled into a tense, albeit temporary, calm. He and Andrew had been sharing a cabin during the mission, a practical arrangement given the nature of their joint operation. The narrow confines of the cabin had become a space for candid conversations and strategy discussions.

Hadler entered the cabin, finding Andrew already seated on one of the small bunks, sorting through some documents. The room was dimly lit, casting long shadows that danced across the metal walls.

“Andrew,” Hadler said as he closed the door behind him, “I wanted to discuss our next steps. What’s your plan now that the mission’s winding down?”

Andrew looked up, a hint of relief in his eyes. “I’ve been meaning to talk to you about that. I can be dropped off at the Gator’s Bog shipyard. It’s a bit of a fringe operation but still Coalition-run. They handle mostly minor shuttles, but they have a sizable ESS office. I can report back to my superiors there and ensure that the ship gets paid.”

Hadler nodded, his mind already processing the logistical implications. “Sounds like a solid plan. I assume you’ll handle your own transit back home after that?”

“Yes,” Andrew confirmed. “I’ll make arrangements from there. I’ll probably head back to the previous mining station where I was stationed before. It’s not too far from Gator’s Bog. I’ll handle the details.”

Hadler’s expression softened slightly, a mix of relief and weariness. “I’ll miss having you around, Andrew. The mission’s been a rough ride, but having you on board has been a stabilizing force.”

Andrew offered a small, appreciative smile. “I’ll miss the crew too. While our time together wasn’t exactly a joyride, it’s been productive. I’ve seen firsthand the lengths your team has gone to for this mission. They’ve done an admirable job avenging that lost submarine.”

There was a moment of silence as Hadler took in Andrew's words. The weight of the mission had taken its toll on both men, but there was a shared understanding of the significance of their efforts.

"Thank you," Hadler said quietly. "It means a lot to hear that. The crew's done their best under difficult circumstances. It's good to know their efforts are recognized."

Andrew nodded. "They deserve recognition. And as for me, I appreciate the opportunity to work with your team. It's been a challenging, but valuable experience."

Hadler walked over to a small storage compartment, pulling out a bottle of synthetic whiskey. He poured two glasses and handed one to Andrew. "Here's to a job well done, and to whatever comes next."

Andrew took the glass, clinking it gently against Hadler's. "To the job, and to the crew. It's been a tough mission, but we've made it through."

As they sipped their drinks, Hadler's mind wandered back to the days ahead. The Gator's Bog shipyard loomed on the horizon, a practical waypoint in their journey. He knew that while their mission was nearing its end, there was still work to be done—both in ensuring proper payment and in preparing for future challenges.

The pair of old captains turned in for the night.

The night had not been kind to Captain Hadler and would not be so again. As he finally collapsed onto his bunk, the oppressive weight of the mission seemed to coalesce into a suffocating nightmare. The cabin, dimly lit by a solitary, flickering overhead light, felt like a tomb. The incessant hum of the submarine's machinery outside did little to dispel the grim atmosphere that pervaded the room.

In his restless sleep, Hadler found himself standing alone in the Resolute's bar. The familiar, comforting space had transformed into a macabre tableau. The bar's polished surface gleamed dully in the flickering, cold light of the ship's emergency lamps, casting long, distorted shadows. An eerie silence filled the air, broken only by the occasional drip of condensation from the overhead pipes, each drop echoing like a metronome marking time in a dead world.

Before him stood an audience of hollow-eyed corpses, their faces frozen in an unsettling, lifeless cheer. The bar stools were occupied by these spectral figures, their mouths stretched into grotesque smiles that spoke of forgotten joy. Hadler, trying to salvage some semblance of normalcy, attempted to deliver a rousing speech, but the words came out as a garbled whisper, swallowed by the oppressive silence. The scene was a grim mockery of the camaraderie he cherished, a twisted reflection of the bond he had with his crew.

He tried to move closer to his audience, but his feet felt like they were mired in wet, heavy sand. Every step was a struggle, each movement slow and agonizingly laborious. The room seemed to close in on him, the walls bending inward as if to suffocate him. The corpses continued their

silent, spectral applause, their eyes unseeing, their smiles frozen in a macabre dance of dead cheer.

Hadler jolted awake with a start, his breath coming in short, ragged gasps. The early morning light filtered weakly through the small porthole of the cabin, casting a pale, sickly glow over the room. The cabin's cramped, utilitarian furnishings seemed more oppressive in the dim light, the cold metal and harsh angles serving as a stark contrast to the warmth of the dream that had become a nightmare.

Andrew, already up and dressed, sat at the small desk with a look of concern etched on his face. The old captain's expression was a blend of worry and curiosity, a stark contrast to the harsh reality that Hadler had just escaped from.

"Captain, are you alright?" Andrew's voice was gentle, almost soothing, cutting through the remnants of Hadler's unsettling dream.

Hadler took a moment to collect himself, rubbing a trembling hand over his face as if to erase the lingering shadows of his nightmare. "I'm fine, Andrew. Just a bad dream. I—" He paused, struggling to find the right words to explain the weight of his unease. "I think it's because I skipped my usual ritual. Normally, I have one last night in port, a drink with my department heads before we leave. It's a tradition of sorts, a way to mark the end of one chapter and the beginning of another."

Andrew's eyes widened slightly in understanding. "I see. It's part of your routine, isn't it?"

"Exactly," Hadler said, nodding slowly. "Breaking from that routine... it feels like we've somehow jinxed ourselves. I'm hoping it's not an omen of things to come."

Andrew gave a reassuring smile, though it did little to dispel the grim aura that hung over them. "It's natural to feel that way. Routines and rituals help ground us, especially in this line of work. But remember, the mission was successful, and the crew has done their job admirably."

Hadler managed a weary smile, the lines of exhaustion etched deeply into his face. "Yes, the mission went well. I just need to remind myself that sometimes, things don't go exactly as planned. It doesn't always mean disaster."

"Absolutely," Andrew said, his voice firm and steady. "And even if it does, it's not the end of the world. You've got a strong crew and a solid plan. That counts for a lot."

Hadler nodded, taking solace in Andrew's words. The nightmare had left a sour taste in his mouth, but it also served as a grim reminder of the importance of routine and the need to face the unknown with unyielding determination. As he swung his legs over the edge of the bed and began to prepare for the day ahead, he felt a renewed sense of resolve.

The morning aboard the *Resolute* began with its usual blend of routine efficiency and a tinge of grim anticipation. As the crew settled into their roles, Captain Hadler and the command team

orchestrated the final stages of their operation, focusing on the navigation to Gators Bog Shipyard. The shipyard was a minor but crucial destination, primarily known for producing small shuttles and hosting an ESS office that would handle the necessary administrative tasks.

Andrew, now a well-liked figure among the crew, had forged an unexpected camaraderie with Navigator Simmons. The two had shared countless stories and jokes over the course of the mission, a rare but welcome respite from the grim reality of their work. Hadler noted their budding friendship with a hint of amusement. It was a small reminder of the humanity that persisted even in the darkest corners of their lives.

Simmons was busy plotting the course, his fingers dancing over the holographic controls as he mapped out the most efficient route to the shipyard. The familiar hum of the ship's engines and the rhythmic clattering of machinery in the background were comforting sounds, a stark contrast to the chaos of the previous days.

Hadler approached Andrew, who was already preparing for departure. "Everything in order?" Hadler asked, his tone a mix of professional courtesy and personal concern.

Andrew nodded, his expression serious but appreciative. "Everything's good, Captain. I'm ready to disembark and get things sorted with the ESS office. Thanks for ensuring we got here safely."

Hadler gave a reassuring nod. "It's the least I could do. You've been a valuable asset to this mission. I want to make sure you reach the shipyard without any hitches. And, of course, we need to make sure we're properly compensated for our efforts."

Andrew's lips curved into a small smile. "I appreciate it. It's been quite the journey, and while it wasn't exactly a pleasure cruise, I'm grateful for the professionalism and camaraderie I've experienced."

As the Resolute approached the shipyard, the looming structure of Gators Bog came into view. The shipyard, though modest, was bustling with activity. Cranes and maintenance drones flitted about, and the hum of industry filled the air. The sight was oddly reassuring—a sign that life continued beyond their immediate sphere of conflict.

Hadler, standing at the bridge, observed the scene with a practiced eye. "Simmons, make sure we dock smoothly. We don't want any last-minute complications."

Simmons responded with a nod, his fingers expertly maneuvering the controls. "Aye, Captain. We'll be docked in a few minutes."

The crew prepared for the docking procedure, and soon the Resolute glided into position with the practiced ease of countless successful arrivals. The docking clamps engaged with a reassuring clunk, and the shipyard personnel began to approach.

Hadler and Andrew made their way to the airlock, their final moments aboard marked by a sense of both closure and anticipation. Andrew's brief but impactful presence had left its mark, and Hadler was determined to see the mission through to its final administrative step.

As the airlock cycled open and Andrew stepped out onto the shipyard's metal deck, Hadler offered a firm handshake. "Good luck, Andrew. And remember, if you ever find yourself in need of a good crew, you know where to find us."

Andrew shook his hand with a nod. "Thanks, Captain. I'll make sure the payment process goes smoothly. I'll be in touch about any follow-up details."

With Andrew safely disembarked and the ship's finances set to be sorted, Captain Hadler faced a significant crossroads. The immediate relief of completing the mission and ensuring payment was a brief respite. The deeper challenge lay in deciding the crew's next course of action.

The fringes of Europa offered both risk and reward. The known waters of more established routes held the promise of familiar contracts and trusted contacts. They could find solace in the stability of routine, returning to more predictable, albeit less thrilling, assignments. This would be a return to safety, a chance to catch their breath and replenish their resources while avoiding the perils of uncharted territories.

Yet, the fringes held their own allure. The possibility of high-stakes missions and untapped opportunities beckoned with a certain tantalizing promise. It was a gamble that could yield substantial rewards but came with the risk of unpredictable threats and treacherous environments. For a crew accustomed to the edge of danger, the lure of pushing further into the unknown might be hard to resist. The chance to carve out a niche in these less-charted realms, to become pioneers in a world of shadow and uncertainty, was a powerful temptation.

The captain sat in his quarters, the quiet hum of the shipyard's activity filtering through the bulkheads. He reviewed the crew's current state—exhausted but resolute, battle-hardened but longing for some semblance of normalcy. He thought about their recent experiences, the heavy toll of the mission, and the lingering sense of unease that had accompanied their operations. It wasn't just about the practicalities of their next assignment; it was about the crew's morale, their well-being, and their readiness to face whatever came next.

Returning to familiar waters meant reconnecting with old contacts, a predictable rhythm that could offer stability but lacked the thrill of exploration. It would provide a safe haven, a chance to regroup and strategize, perhaps even allowing them to indulge in some well-earned downtime.

On the other hand, pushing further into the fringe could offer new contracts, unknown territories, and the possibility of greater rewards. It was a path fraught with risk, but it held the promise of discovery and potential glory. For a crew that thrived on the edge, it might be an opportunity to embrace their true nature, to challenge themselves beyond the boundaries of the known.

Hadler knew he had to weigh these options carefully. The decision would affect not just the ship's operational strategy but the crew's mental and physical well-being. He had to consider

their endurance, their readiness for the unknown, and the potential impact on their overall morale.

As he contemplated these choices, he knew that his decision would need to balance the pragmatic with the aspirational. It was a call that required not just strategic thinking but an understanding of his crew's spirit and the broader implications of their path. Whether to return to the safety of the known or to continue exploring the enigmatic fringes would be a choice that defined their next chapter, shaping their journey and their future in the cold, uncharted depths of Icy Europa.